

{Sunday}

Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

JHARKHAND GOVT REACHES OUT, BUT STIR TO CONTINUE

Vishal Kant

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RANCHI: The Jharkhand government on Saturday held talks with different groups of students protesting over alleged paper leaks and irregularities in recruitment exams, but failed to break the deadlock, with the agitators deciding to continue their stir. Late on Saturday, the group of ministers met chief minister Hemant Soren to apprise him of the details of the meetings. —**PTI**

VIJAY MEETS TN MPs ON DELIMITATION; DMK, AIADMK SKIP

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister Vijay on Saturday chaired a meeting of state parliamentarians to discuss the Centre's proposed delimitation exercise and its likely impact on the state. The meeting was boycotted by the DMK and the AIADMK, which dismissed the deliberations as a "farce" and a "drama", respectively. —**PTI**

AKALI DAL BACKS WOMEN'S QUOTA AND DELIMITATION

Gurpreet Singh Nibber

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CHANDIGARH: The Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) on Saturday announced its support for the women's quota and the delimitation exercise, calling for their immediate implementation and backing the Centre's proposal for a uniform 50% increase in the number of seats for all states. —**PTI**

PM asks students to put nation's benefit over personal gains

Gargi Shukla

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged graduating engineers at IIT-Delhi on Saturday to measure their careers against the country's needs rather than salary slips or startup valuations, telling students that "the basis of every decision of yours should be what the benefit to the country will be".

Addressing the 57th convocation ceremony, Modi told the graduating class that an IIT degree was "a mandate to contribute to the nation", and framed the years ahead as a test distinct from anything the students had faced in the classroom. "Unlike your university exams, life's most critical challenges are entirely out of syllabus," he said, urging students to identify "the questions the world has stopped asking" rather than simply answering the ones already set for them.

Modi set that challenge against a rapidly shifting global landscape, telling students that the pace of technological change made it impossible to predict with confidence what industries or professions would look like in 20 or 30 years. "The strategic equations of the world are changing rapidly. The global balance of power is shifting

continued on -6



PM Narendra Modi and education minister Pralhad Joshi at the 57th Convocation Ceremony of IIT-Delhi on Saturday. PHOTO

SOME PEOPLE TRIED TO MISLEAD YOUNGSTERS: PRADHAN ON GEN Z STIR
Former Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Saturday said Gen Z was misled during the protests over the NEET paper leak controversy that eventually led to his resignation, and added that he had urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to acknowledge and address the concerns of the protesters. Speaking at a felicitation ceremony for Padma awardees in Sambalpur, Pradhan said he met Modi and sought his permission to acknowledge the aspirations of the younger generation rather than allow their grievances to be exploited. Modi agreed and later addressed the issue himself, he said. —**PTI**

IN PRAYAGRAJ, RAHUL LOOKS TO CORNER GOVT OVER UNEMPLOYMENT
Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Saturday said India's youth are the country's biggest strength but their educational qualifications are losing value as degrees no longer guarantee jobs. Addressing the "Chhatron Ki Goon" event at KP Ground in Prayagraj, Gandhi said he wanted to speak to young people about "dard (pain), data, and daulat (wealth)" and highlighted what he described as shrinking employment opportunities across sectors. Gandhi said students pursue education with the hope of finding employment, but "all the doors" leading to jobs had been closed. —**PTI**

SC COLLEGIUM SET TO RECOMMEND 5 NEW HIGH COURT CHIEF JUSTICES

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court collegium has decided to recommend five judges for appointment as chief justices of high courts, people aware of the matter said on Saturday. It has decided to recommend Justice V Kamavansh Rao as chief justice of the Patna high court; Justice Ashwini Kumar Mishra for the Punjab and Haryana HC; Justice Sanjay Prakash Sharma for the Rajasthan HC; Justice Mahesh Chandra Tripathi for the Bombay high court and Justice Ravindra Vithalrao Ghuge for the Calcutta HC. —**PTI**

IAF OFFICER HELD FOR LEAKING DEFENCE INFO TO 'PAK OPERATIVE'

Karn Pratap Singh

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NEW DELHI: A 44-year-old Indian Air Force (IAF) Wing Commander has been arrested on charges of leaking defence-related information, Delhi Police said on Saturday. According to a statement by the police, the officer, whose name is yet to be disclosed, was arrested on May 30 and booked under the Official Secrets Act. He is in Tihar Jail. "He was under active surveillance and was handed over to the suitable law enforcement agencies," an IAF spokesperson said. The woman, who was used to honey-trap the wing commander, could be working for handlers based in Pakistan, said officers. —**PTI**



A Kanwar yatra truck laden with loudspeakers, subwoofers and strobe lights near Dilshad Garden Metro station on Saturday. ARVIND YADAV/HT

Law on mute as Kanwar boomboxes deafen city

Aaditya Khatwani and Snehi Sinha

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NEW DELHI: An HT sound meter registered peaks of 110 decibels at two Kanwar Yatra rest camps in east Delhi as loud-speaker-mounted convoy trucks rolled past. That is roughly as loud as a chainsaw at close range, and more than 30 decibels above every legal ceiling that applies to noise in a residential area.

Even between the passing trucks, ambient noise at both camps — HT took the measurements at multiple occasions on Friday and Saturday — held between 80 and 88 decibels — 25 to 33 decibels above the 55-decibel daytime residential limit set by the Central Pollution Control Board. Because the dec-

Facing the music

Sound levels HT recorded



ibel scale is logarithmic, the 85-decibel readings HT recorded carry roughly a thousand times the sound intensity of that ceiling. The trucks have been grinding into the capital for over a

110 dB
Peak reading as a boombox truck passed

80-88 dB
Persistent ambient noise at two camps between passing trucks

90-107 dB
Typical range when boombox trucks passed the meter

week, and Saturday's surge — the first of the yatra's three peak days, which will send thousands more through the city until Tuesday — swelled the flow further. continued on -6

Hormuz to reopen if conditions met: Iran as Oman pact nears

Reuters

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CAIRO/WASHINGTON/DUBAI: Iran said on Saturday that a deal with Oman on control of the Strait of Hormuz was close but would not be enough to free up the waterway, and the United Arab Emirates said Iran had hit another ship there.

Agreement between Iran and Oman over the strait is seen as vital to a wider deal to end the war that began with U.S. and Israeli attacks on Iran on February 28 and led to Tehran establishing a chokehold over the major energy export route.

A U.S. official, who declined to be identified, had said on Friday that Washington anticipated an agreement soon between Iran and Oman, which sit on either side of the strait, so that normal oil traffic could resume.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said Iran and Oman were "very close" to agreement on a new shipping route through the strait but that reopening it depended on U.S. compensation to Iran.

The secretary of Iran's top national security body, Mohsen Bagher Zolghadr, listed other demands including ending U.S. threats against Iran, stopping

Liberia tanker with 5 Indian seafarers aboard hit; all safe

Yogesh Naik

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MUMBAI: A Liberian-flagged crude oil tanker, MT FRANCE C, was reportedly struck by a projectile on Saturday after crossing the Strait of Hormuz while proceeding west-bound. The vessel has five Indian seafarers onboard, all of whom have been confirmed to be safe. —**PTI**

aggression against Iran and its Lebanese, Palestinian, Yemeni and Iraqi allies, lifting a blockade and sanctions on Iran and freeing Iranian assets.

Oman condemned what it described as repeated attacks on vessels while transiting the strait, without assigning blame, and said that negotiations with Iran on arrangements for shipping through Hormuz were "positive and constructive".

"Oman stresses the importance of avoiding any actions that could harm the region," it said. continued on -6

NCR records 2 more monsoon fatalities



Commuters traverse a waterlogged road in Gurugram on Saturday. The rains across NCR on Friday claimed two lives in the region, it emerged on Saturday. A 26-year-old delivery executive died after reportedly being electrocuted by current leaking from an electric pole while crossing a waterlogged road in Faridabad and an 18-year-old man was swept away in a drain at Priyanka Camp Nala, south Delhi. PHOTO

70-year-old killed as cop's 'drunk' son crashes luxury sedan in Delhi

Karn Pratap Singh

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NEW DELHI: A 70-year-old woman was killed and a family of three, including an eight-year-old girl, were injured when an allegedly drunk 27-year-old man, the son of a police officer, crashed a speeding Mercedes sedan into a hatchback near Narela in northwest Delhi on Saturday morning, police said.

While investigators are yet to receive the driver's medical test results, officers at the scene confirmed that he had been drinking. Police recovered the Mercedes. Police officers said the driver was returning from a party.

According to police, the silver Mercedes E-Class was travelling at such high speed that when it struck the grey Maruti WagonR, in which a couple was travelling

with their daughter, the hatchback was flung away, crushing a woman pedestrian against a parked three-wheeler.

Police identified the Mercedes driver as Shubham Sharma, a resident of Green Valley Apartment in Narela and son of a Haryana Police sub-inspector. Sharma was arrested and booked for rash and negligent driving causing death and injuries.

Modi, Vance discuss trade, energy security

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: US vice president JD Vance dialled Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday to discuss ways to strengthen the bilateral strategic partnership and to exchange views on regional and global issues.

The two leaders agreed to deepen cooperation in areas such as trade, defence, critical technologies and energy security across multiple occasions on Friday and Saturday — held between 80 and 88 decibels — 25 to 33 decibels above the 55-decibel daytime residential limit set by the Central Pollution Control Board. Because the dec-

"Received a phone call from US Vice President JD Vance. We discussed ways to further deepen India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership

PM AND U.S. VP ALSO SPOKE ON DEFENCE AND CRITICAL TECH, AN INDIAN GOVT READOUT SAID

across key areas," Modi said on social media.

Modi and Vance reviewed progress in the bilateral comprehensive global strategic partnership, and noted the "sustained momentum in the high-level engagements", the readout said. They also exchanged views on regional and global develop-

continued on -7

US reviews 60-day grace for terminated foreigners

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WASHINGTON: The US is reviewing a proposal to eliminate the 60-day window for foreign workers holding non-immigrant visas to find employment after a job loss, a move that may force them to leave the country immediately.

A proposal from the Department of Homeland Security is

currently under review at the federal Office of Management and Budget (OMB), according to its website.

If finalised, the proposed regulation would eliminate the 60-day grace period accorded to certain principal non-immigrants and their dependents if the principal's employment ceases before their period of stay expires. —**PTI**

U.S. BILL TO LEVY TARIFFS OVER RUSSIA OIL STARES AT ROADBLOCKS

Shashank Mattoo

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WASHINGTON: The Russia sanctions bill passed by the US Senate on Friday, which authorises tariffs of up to 100% on India and four others for buying Russian energy, faces three obstacles before it can reach Donald Trump for signature — the US House of Representatives is in recess until August 31, a possible September vote could collide with a Trump-Xi Jinping summit, and a coalition of House Democrats and at least one senior Republican are working to strip the tariff provisions altogether. —**PTI**

AMID SPENDING ROW, SPAIN BEGINS PROCESS TO CHANGE ITS ENVOY TO INDIA

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: The Spanish government has begun the process of replacing its ambassador to India, Juan Antonio March, following complaints about allegedly organising cultural events at great expense without clearance from the foreign ministry, according to a media report.

March was appointed as the Envoy Extraordinary in September 2024 and is expected to be replaced within a few weeks. The Objective, a Spanish digital daily newspaper, reported citing its sources. —**PTI**

DHAMI RESPONDS TO PANT'S PUBLIC PLEA OVER BUYING LAND IN U.K'HAND

Dehradun:

Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami on Saturday responded to cricketer Rishi Pant's public request for help in buying land in the state, saying officials have been directed to contact him.

Pant said on X that he had been trying to find land to relocate from Delhi to the state for three years but was unable to do so. —**PTI**

HT Wknd

A PART OF YOUR WEEKLY LIFE

Heavy mettle

Sharmila Dhanraj, 39, was a battered wife and mother. Before that, a child with polio. She has now won India's first-ever athletics gold medal at the Commonwealth Games. I don't bother too much about history. I'd rather create my own, she says

[URBAN] A museum of children's notebooks in Milan offers notes on what children really think, the battles they fight, and ways in which they wish their world was different

Step write in

MAHA GOVT SET TO CLEAR ₹100-CR BARAMATI AIRPORT UPGRADE PROJECT

Yogesh Naik

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MUMBAI: The Maharashtra government is set to give final clearance to a ₹100-crore upgrade plan for Baramati airport, six months after deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar died in a crash there on January 28. A four-tonder will be purchased, alongside a fire station, technical block, emergency room and a prefabricated air traffic control tower. The runway will be repaved, said officials. Authorities will also build a runway end safety area — a 80-metre buffer at each end of the runway to arrest aircraft that overshoot or under-shoot on landing. —**PTI**

{ LONG JOURNEY TO RECOVERY }

Hilsa spotted in Ganga near Ghazipur in UP, decades after barrage cut off migration route

Sanjeev K Jha and Jasveer Gandhokh

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NEW DELHI: Scientists spotted two hilsa in the Ganga along Ghazipur town in Uttar Pradesh earlier this week, decades after they were believed to have disappeared from the upper and middle stretches of the river, a sighting that scientists said may be an indication that the waters were once again conducive for the species.

A senior Namami Ganga official in Ghazipur confirmed the sighting. "Some more hilsas were

Ray of hope?

What was spotted

Scientists this week found two hilsa in the Ganga near Ghazipur in Uttar Pradesh. The sighting was confirmed by the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) and the Central Indian Fisheries Research Institute (CIFRI).

Why it matters

Hilsa's presence depends on adequate flow, dissolved oxygen, suitable temperature and unobstructed passage between the sea and freshwater breeding grounds.

Cause for caution

Scientists say true restoration will need evidence of natural migration, spawning, survival and successful reproduction sustained over time, and that breeding in freshwater is the critical test.

Inland Fisheries Research Institute (CIFRI).

The two together weighed 740g, said officials.

Officials said the finding was significant not because two fish alone can establish a population, but because Ghazipur lies well upstream of the Farakka Barrage in West Bengal that has disrupted the hilsa's travel and migration patterns since the 1970s.

The species was once known to travel towards the Ganga's upper reaches, with historical records showing its presence as far upstream as Prayagraj and headquarters," said the official, who asked to be named. The sighting was also confirmed by officials at the Central

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DMK, AIADMK boycott Vijay's deimitation meet

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CHENNAI: Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Saturday chaired a meeting of Tamil Nadu MPs on the Centre's proposed deimitation exercise, but the DMK and AIADMK boycotted it, with the two parties calling the deliberations a "farce" and a "hurriedly staged drama".

Vijay led the discussions on the proposed deimitation and its likely impact on Tamil Nadu. MPs from the ruling TVK's alliance parties, Congress, VCK, MDK and IUML, as well as friendly parties CPI and CPI(M), attended the meeting. Congress MP Karti Chidambaram said around 21 MPs from both houses participated.

Eleven Congress MPs, two DMK each from CPI, CPI(M) and VCK, and one MP each from MDK and IUML took part. The DMK, AIADMK, DMK, MNM and PMK did not participate. The DMK has 22 Lok Sabha and eight Rajya Sabha MPs. The AIADMK has four Rajya Sabha MPs, while its ally PMK has none. DMK alliance partners MNM and DMKD have one Rajya Sabha MP each.

Congress veteran P Chidambaram, VCK chief Tho Thirumavalavan, CPI(M)'s Su Venkatesan, DMK's Durai Vaiko



C Joseph Vijay

and Congress's Jothimani were among those who attended. Tamil Nadu chief secretary M Sai Kumar had sent separate invitations to MPs on August 6 and 7, government sources said. The meeting was held at Kallivanar Aranganam, a government-owned auditorium near the Secretariat. Senior DMK leader A Raja told reporters at Perambalur that the meeting was "a farce, a laughable exercise" since the TVK regime was deliberating about something that it was not aware of. "Is it fair?", he asked.

The AIADMK called the meeting a "hurriedly staged drama", pointing out that no new deimitation Bill has been introduced in Parliament and there has been no official announcement regarding it.

"Why is the chief minister hurriedly staging a drama in the

name of an MP's meeting? After ignoring the demand of all the opposition parties to hold an all-party meeting to discuss the Cauvery-Mekedatu issue 'happening right before our eyes', why is the CM holding a meeting for a Bill that has not even been introduced, the AIADMK asked in a statement. 'To this day, the Mettur Dam has not been opened. There is no water in the delta districts. Without answering the tears of farmers, this government's diversionary political drama will never be supported,' the AIADMK said.

A DMK MP told PTI that inviting MPs was a flawed move and the government should have invited top party leaders.

"The MPs have a mandate to follow the party line. This meeting is unnecessary. DMK is fully committed to protecting Tamil Nadu's interests and our party chief M K Stalin is the first to raise his voice against deimitation and he has spoken and fought against it in order to protect the interests of Tamil Nadu," he said.

DMK MP K Kanimozhi, however, said her party was "not completely against the deimitation", but opposed any exercise that could reduce Tamil Nadu's voice in Parliament.

"We are not completely against deimitation. We are ask-

ing for a fair deimitation. During the election, DMK President and that time CM M K Stalin had made it clear that protecting Tamil Nadu was more important than deimitation," Kanimozhi said.

More than winning the election, we need to protect the rights of Tamil Nadu. That is our aim and our leader's aim," Kanimozhi said.

Kanimozhi also questioned the purpose of the meeting and alleged it was intended to divert attention from the Mekedatu dam issue with Karnataka.

"32 MPs did not participate in the meeting and there is no clarity yet on the outcome of today's meeting convened by the Chief Minister on deimitation. This MP's meeting has been convened with the intention of diverting attention from the Mekedatu dam issue in 'Tamil Nadu', she said.

On Congress criticism of the boycott, Kanimozhi said the DMK did not want lessons on its political identity or record of standing up for Tamil Nadu. "Unfortunately, I think the Congress has forgotten the history of the DMK. We have stood against the Congress also on many occasions over the past many decades. We don't need anyone else to tell us who we are," she said.

SEARCH STILL ON FOR 3 MISSING FISHERMEN: COPS

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The search for three fishermen who have been missing since July 31 following separate boat mishaps in Thiruvananthapuram and Kollam districts will continue as they remain untraced on Saturday, police said.

The search, which entered its ninth day, was carried out in Vayalunadu and Muthalappuzha Thiruvananthapuram district and Neendakara in Kollam district. Gautam Krishna (26) of Puthenthur was missing after a fishing boat capsized at Neendakara on July 31. Gautam's father, Radhakrishnan (48), and grandfather, Rajeevan (74), who were also on the boat, died in the mishap.

Search was intensified on Friday with additional Coastal Police boats deployed and Coast Guard helicopters and planes pressed into service, officials said. However, Gautam could not be traced, officials said, adding that the operation would continue on Sunday.

{ OPERATION MUKTA }

15 B'lishi nationals detained: B'luru cops

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BENGALURU: The Bengaluru police on Saturday launched a citywide verification drive to identify foreign nationals allegedly staying illegally in the city, deploying more than 500 personnel under "Operation Mukta". The drive covered more than 30 locations in the Whitefield division and several areas in Electronic City.

In the Whitefield division, teams led by DCP Saidu Adavath conducted simultaneous checks in Whitefield, Varthur, Kadugodi, Balagere Road, Belandur, Marathahalli and Mahadevapura.

Whitefield DCP Saidu Adavath said the operation was being conducted across Bengaluru on the directions of the city police commissioner and was part of a continuous exercise.

"We have carried out similar operations in the past and deported foreign nationals found staying illegally. If we find anyone without valid documents, their details will be forwarded to the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO). Based on the verification report, legal proceedings for deportation will be initiated," he said.

Officials aware of the matter said around 40 suspicious people were taken into custody for verification in the Whitefield division, while four were identified as Bangladeshi nationals based on documents recovered from them. Documents of the rest of the suspects are currently being verified.

THE SEARCHES ALSO COVERED MAKESHIFT SETTLEMENTS WHERE PEOPLE FROM B'ESH, WEST BENGAL, ASSAM, BIHAR, NEPAL WERE FOUND RESIDING

"If we find an identity card or any other document indicating that they are from another country, we will write to the FRRO," the DCP said.

The searches also covered makeshift settlements where people from Bangladesh, West Bengal, Assam, Bihar and Nepal were found residing. Residents were asked to produce identity and citizenship documents, including Aadhaar cards and voter IDs.

Those unable to provide documents or found suspicious were taken to police stations for further questioning.

According to police sources, several of those found in the settlements appeared to be working as construction labourers, domestic help, drivers and delivery personnel. The DCP also warned property owners about renting premises without verifying tenants' credentials.

"Owners who provide houses or accommodation to illegal immigrants without verifying their documents will also face legal action. We have already registered 10 such cases in the Whitefield division," he said.

The Electronic City division also reported significant findings. Police detained 1,500 suspected persons and examined their nationality and identity documents.

Detailed verification of passports, visas and other records led to the detection of 15 Bangladeshi nationals allegedly staying illegally.

Of the 15, eight were detected within Bengal police station limits and seven under Parappana Agrahara police station limits. They have been taken into custody for further legal proceedings. Electronic City DCP Narayan said 23 special teams comprising 295 police officers and personnel were deployed for the operation.

The teams searched 29 identified locations, including construction sites, temporary shelters and other suspected hideouts. "We have so far identified 15 Bangladeshi nationals during the verification," Narayan said.

The drive was part of a continuing exercise to identify illegal immigrants from different countries and initiate deportation proceedings wherever required.

The operation comes amid a recent Karnataka HC intervention in a case involving a doctor who identified a Bangladeshi national allegedly residing illegally in Bengaluru.

Police had registered a case against the doctor on the case against the migrant. The High Court stayed further investigation in the criminal cases registered against the doctor-activist.

with inputs from PTI

DYFI protests delay in search for fishermen



Members and leaders of the Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) hold placards and banners during a demonstration outside the State Secretariat in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, on Saturday. Protesters alleged administrative inaction and delays in search operations for fishermen missing after separate boats had capsized off the Kollam and Muthalappuzha coasts.

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The search for three fishermen who have been missing since July 31 following separate boat mishaps in Thiruvananthapuram and Kollam districts will continue as they remain untraced on Saturday, police said.

The search, which entered its ninth day, was carried out in Vayalunadu and Muthalappuzha Thiruvananthapuram district and Neendakara in Kollam district. Gautam Krishna (26) of Puthenthur was missing after a fishing boat capsized at Neendakara on July 31. Gautam's father, Radhakrishnan (48), and grandfather, Rajeevan (74), who were also on the boat, died in the mishap.

Search was intensified on Friday with additional Coastal Police boats deployed and Coast Guard helicopters and planes pressed into service, officials said. However, Gautam could not be traced, officials said, adding that the operation would continue on Sunday.

Savarkar quiz question sparks political row in Kerala; minister orders probe

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A political row erupted in Kerala over a question in a school quiz that described Hinduist ideology V Savarkar as a freedom fighter "who received the most severe punishment from the British", prompting General Education Minister N Samsudheen to order an inquiry.

The minister directed the Director of General Education to investigate who prepared and conducted the quiz and take stringent action against those responsible, he said, in a statement on Saturday.

The "Freedom Quiz" was conducted on August 6 for lower primary students in schools in the Kasargod, Kumbha and



N Samsudheen

Manjerwar sub-districts.

According to the minister's office, the quiz was not part of the activity calendar of either the Social Science Club or the General Education Department, and neither had authorised anyone to prepare the questions or conduct the competition independently. "The person who held the historically incorrect question holds a prejudiced view," the statement said, adding that

the minister had instructed the Education Director to identify those responsible and take strict action. The disputed question asked: "Who is the freedom fighter that received the most severe punishment from the British?" with Savarkar given as the answer. According to reports, teachers at the school with the Social Science Club had prepared the questionnaire.

The issue triggered sharp criticism from the CPI(M) and Left student and youth organisations, which accused the Congress-led UDF government of allowing the "Sangh Parivar agenda" to enter the educational system. CPI(M) veteran and former Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan accused the UDF government of "colluding" with the RSS and alleged that attempts

were being made to hide Savarkar's "real history" and glorify him. Addressing a press conference in Kannur, Vijayan alleged that the Congress and RSS were "attempting to rewrite history," and said the issue should also be viewed in the context of efforts to implement the Centre's new education policy in Kerala.

Former General Education Minister V Sivankutty alleged that the quiz question was part of an attempt to "safonise" the state's general education system and distort the history of the freedom struggle. Sivankutty demanded a comprehensive inquiry and the Centre to withdraw the disputed question and answer. He also sought an apology from the General Education Department to students and the public.

CONGRESS LEADER BOOKED FOR ANIMAL SACRIFICE

HYDERABAD: An FIR was registered against a ruling Congress leader in Sangareddy district of Telangana for alleged animal sacrifice.

The case was registered under Section 325 of BNS (mis-chievous by killing or maiming animal) on August 7 following a complaint made by Adulapuram Goutham, cruelty prevention manager at Stray Animal Foundation of India (NGO), police said on Saturday.

Goutham stated in his complaint that videos of the animal sacrifice incident, organised at a village on August 5 by the Congress leader, were uploaded on social media.

Three arrested for murdering K'taka Cong leader in Udipi after manhunt, say police

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BENGALURU: Karnataka Police arrested three people on Saturday in connection with the daylight murder of Congress leader and contractor David D'Souza, 55, at Mudrangudi in Kaup taluk.

D'Souza was attacked around 3.45pm on Friday after he arrived at the Prince Enterprises office in the S. S. Church complex at Mudrangudi. He was walking towards the driver's side door of his Thar when two assailants injured a motorcycle allegedly



One of the accused, Raju, was injured after he allegedly opened fire to escape.

opened fire at him. A bullet struck him in the head.

D'Souza was rushed to a private hospital in Udipi, but doctors declared him dead on arrival. CCTV footage from the area reportedly captured the assailants fleeing on a motorcycle after the shooting.

Following the murder, Shiva police registered a case and they received information that three suspects who were involved in the killing were travelling towards Bhatkal in a bus.

Following up on the information the police team entered in Byndoor and attempted to apprehend the suspects.

According to police, one of the accused, identified as Raju, 42, a native of Pilwa in Uttar Pradesh, allegedly pushed Kaup police sub-inspector Tejwasi and fired at the police with a pistol while attempting to flee.

Udipi SP Harinarayan Shankar said, "During the attempt to apprehend the accused, Raju attacked PSI Tejwasi and opened fire at the police."

"To protect themselves and prevent his escape, the police fired at his leg and apprehended him. A pistol was also recovered from his possession," the SP said.

KISHAN REDDY SEEKS 50% OF HYD REVENUE FOR DEVELOPMENT

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Alleging that the Congress government in Telangana is "neglecting" several areas of Hyderabad while focusing on the IT hub, Union Minister Kishan Reddy on Saturday demanded that at least 50 per cent of the city's revenue be spent on its development.

Thoodu Hyderabad contributes 70 per cent of the revenue to the Telangana government, not even five per cent of it is spent on the city, he cautioned. Kishan Reddy, Lok Sabha member from Secunderabad, claimed. Both the previous BRS regime and the present Congress government have focused on IT hub areas like Hitech City, Kondapur, and Madhapur, while neglecting the "original" Hyderabad areas, such as Sanathnagar, Secunderabad, Musheerabad, Amberpet, and Khairatabad, he alleged.

The Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation and Hyderabad Water Works, the main agencies responsible for the city's development, are facing financial problems and are unable to pay their employees' salaries, he told reporters here.

"The government is spending Hyderabad's revenue on other things. I urge Chief Minister Revanth Reddy, who also holds the Municipal portfolio, to spend at least 50 per cent of Hyderabad's revenue on the city's development," Kishan Reddy said.

Tribal groups in AP observe bandh over quota, land rights

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HYDERABAD: Activists in Andhra Pradesh's Alluri Sitarama Raju and Polavaram districts observed a total shutdown on Saturday following a call by several Adivasi organisations demanding restoration of the government's commitment to 100 per cent reservation for tribals in teacher recruitment and strict implementation of the 170 Land Transfer and Land Acquisition to protect tribal lands.

A tense situation prevailed in Paderu, headquarters of Alluri Sitarama Raju district, as protesters staged demonstrations and clashed with police who tried to prevent them from taking out a rally. Leaders of several Adivasi organisations, including Adivasi Adhikar Rashtriya Manch, Adivasi Girijana Sangham, CITU and Girijana Samakhya district secretary Radhakrishna, began their protest early in the morning with a sit-in at the RTC complex junction in Paderu. As part of the bandh, protesters blocked roads, halting buses and private vehicles. Police were deployed in large numbers to maintain law and order. Authorities later cleared the roads, allowing buses and other vehicles to resume movement. However, most buses operated without passengers due to the shutdown.

The bandh had a widespread impact across the district, with protests reported in several

AS PART OF THE BANDH, PROTESTERS BLOCKED ROADS, HALTING RTC BUSES AND PRIVATE VEHICLES

mandals, including G Madugula, Pedabayal, Munchingiputtu, Araku Valley, Dumbiruguda and Holapuri. Munchingiputtu mandal headquarters, protesters continued their sit-in on the roads despite heavy rain.

The shutdown also extended to the neighbouring Polavaram district, where tribal groups staged similar protests demanding strict implementation of laws protecting tribal rights.

According to Adivasi Adhikar Rashtriya Manch national executive member P Appala Naidu, GO No 3 was issued in January 10, 2004, during the earlier regime of CM Chandrababu Naidu in the undivided Andhra Pradesh, providing 100 per cent reservation for tribals in the Scheduled Areas. "After a protracted legal battle, the Supreme Court struck down the GO as unconstitutional in April 2020, stating that providing 100 per cent quota to a particular community was legally unacceptable. We are now asking for an alternative legislation to restore the rights of the Adivasis," Appala Naidu said.

T'gana warns farmers against paddy amid low water levels

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HYDERABAD: Telangana has cautioned farmers against taking up water-intensive crops, including paddy, during the current Kharif season in command areas where irrigation projects have received inadequate inflows so far, as reservoir levels remain around half of their total capacity.

State Irrigation minister N. Utam Kumar Reddy, along with agriculture minister Tummalam Nageswara Rao, excise minister Juppala Krishna Rao and chief secretary Sanjay Jaju, held a video conference with district collectors on Saturday to review the drought-like situation across the state. Utam Kumar Reddy said the current reservoir levels, coupled with the rainfall outlook

for the latter part of the monsoon, required extremely cautious crop planning. "Though there are appreciable inflows into Krishna and Godavari rivers in the recent past due to heavy rains in the upstream in Maharashtra and Karnataka, the water levels in many reservoirs are not sufficient to take up water-intensive crops," he said.

As of Saturday, storage in all small, medium and major reservoirs stood at 57.77 TMC (thousand million cubic feet), against a total capacity of 1,059.30 TMC — 50.77% of the total capacity. Among the major reservoirs, only Srisailem reservoir on the Krishna river has reached a water level of 87.62 feet, against its full reservoir level (FRL) of 88.5 feet. Its storage stood at 169.47 TMC against a total



N Utam Kumar Reddy

capacity of 215.81 TMC.

Nagarajanasagar reservoir, meanwhile, had a water level of 51.5 feet against its FRL of 59.0 feet, with storage of 140 TMC against a capacity of 312 TMC. In the Godavari basin, Srisailem project reservoir recorded a water level of 10.78 feet against its FRL of 10.91 feet. Sripada Velampally project had a water level of 48.1 feet against an FRL of

48.5 feet, while Singur reservoir stood at 16.90 feet against an FRL of 17.15 feet.

"The minister said water levels in Nagarajanasagar and Srisailem project were yet to improve to the desired levels. He asked district collectors and irrigation officials to widely publicise the current storage position in the state's major reservoirs."

"Farmers in vulnerable command areas should instead be encouraged to take up alternative and less water-intensive crops, depending on soil conditions and local agricultural practices," he directed district administrators to clearly communicate the water situation to farmers before they commit themselves to water-intensive crops.

"However, the rainfall

MY INDIA

Rajjiu, Rahul trade barbs over women's quota, delimitation

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NEW DELHI: Union parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijju and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi were locked in a war of words on Saturday over the women's reservation bill, amid a stalemate over the Centre's move to link it to the proposed delimitation exercise. The exchange began after Gandhi dismissed women's safety and freedom of expression in a post on X, prompting Rijju to call it a "visible change of heart about women" and challenging Gandhi to support the women's quota bill. Gandhi hit back, questioning why the legislation was being unnecessarily linked to delimitation.



Rahul Gandhi and Kiren Rijju

The development comes amid repeated attempts by Rijju to reach out to Gandhi to break the ongoing deadlock in Parliament regarding the passage of the Constitution Amendment Bill linked to delimitation and the Women's Reservation Act, 2023, which reserves one-third of seats for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies. On August 6, Rijju had a telephonic conversation with Gandhi to seek support for the passage of the women's reservation and delimitation bills, but the leader of opposition insisted on converting an all-party meeting on the proposed legislation, officials aware of the matter had said.

On Friday, dismissing women's safety and freedom of expression, Gandhi said in a video posted on X, "The energy of India's women is trapped, is not allowed to express itself, is not allowed to imagine. For me, no country can be successful if the women in the country are not expressing themselves," adding, "Our country is stunted and incomplete without the expression of our women."

Reacting to Gandhi's remarks, Rijju posted on X, "There's a visible change of heart in Shri Rahul Gandhi ji about women. Now, I hope Congress Party will support the Women's Reservation Bill unanimously."

Gandhi hit back, saying, "Mr Rijju, as you would know better than you, as the Minister of Parliamentary Affairs — that the Women's Reservation Bill 2023 has already been passed unanimously, with the full support of the Congress. The question is, why has it still not been implemented even after three years, and why do you now want to unnecessarily link delimitation?" He implemented the 2023 law. Without any conditions.

Rahul flags 'shrinking job opportunities' for youth

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PRAVARGA: Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, on Saturday said India's youth are the country's biggest strength but their educational qualifications are losing value as degrees no longer guarantee jobs despite the financial burden on students and their families.

Addressing the 'Chhatron Ki Ganga' event at KP Ground in Pravar, Gandhi said the aim is to speak to young people about "dard" (pain), data, and daulat (wealth) and highlighted what he described as shrinking employment opportunities across sectors.

"You are the power and pride of India. When I say this, I am talking about every Indian citizen. This affecting them, this affecting you about dard (pain), data, and daulat (wealth)," he said.

Gandhi said students pursue education with the hope of finding employment, but "all the doors" leading to jobs had been closed. He said no other country has such a large pool of young talent.

Referring to recent student-led protests, Gandhi praised young people for speaking out against issues affecting them. "Youths

Implement without delay: Akali Dal extends support to both bills

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CHANDIGARH: The Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) on Saturday announced its support for the women's reservation bill and the delimitation bill, calling for their immediate implementation and backing the Centre's proposal for a uniform 50% increase in the number of seats for all states.



Sukhbir Singh Badal

The decision was taken at a meeting of senior SAD leaders in Chandigarh, chaired by party president Sukhbir Singh Badal, a day after he met Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the latter's office in the Parliament House complex in New Delhi.

The meeting between the two leaders has triggered fresh speculation about a possible rapprochement between the SAD and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which were former allies. The party's support comes as the Centre makes another attempt to secure parliamentary approval for a Constitution Amendment Bill providing for 33% reservation for women in legislatures.

The government has also proposed redrawing Lok Sabha constituencies following delimitation and increasing the total number of Lok Sabha seats. Announcing the party's position, Badal said the SAD favoured a "fair and equitable" delimitation exercise that would ensure equal representation for all states.

"The Shiromani Akali Dal supported the proposal which was put up by the Government of India on the floor of the House for a uniform increase of 50% of seats of all states," Badal said in a post on X. He added that both women's reservation and delimitation should be implemented without further delay.

On women's reservation, Badal said the SAD drew inspiration from the teachings of Sikh Gurus, who championed the dignity, equality and equal rights of women.

Union minister Kiren Rijju welcomed the party's stance, saying, "I wholeheartedly welcome this very important decision taken by Shiromani Akali Dal following the example set by Shiromani Gurdwara Parbhandhak Committee. We must come together to empower women with a fair and equitable delimitation that ensures equal representation."

CM Vijay holds meet to discuss delimitation; DMK, AIADMK skip

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CHENNAI: Chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Saturday chaired a meeting of Tamil Nadu MPs on the Centre's proposed delimitation and it was boycotted by the DMK and the AIADMK which dubbed the deliberations a "farce" and a "drama".



Vijay

Vijay led the discussions on the proposal of the Centre to carry out delimitation and its likely impact on the state.

MPs belonging to ruling TVK's alliance parties, the Congress, VCK, MDMK and ILMK, and friendly parties, the CPI and CPI(M), took part in the meeting. In total, 19 MPs participated.

Eleven Congress MPs, two MDMK and ILMK each from the DMK and ILMK took part. DMK's alliance partners, MNN and DMK, which have one RS MP each, did not take part.

AIADMK, which has four MPs in the Upper House and its ally the PMK, which has one MP, also in the RS, did not participate. The DMK has 22 Lok Sabha and 8 Rajya Sabha MPs.

Congress veteran leader P Chidambaram, VCK chief Thiruvalluvar were among the participants. Marxist party's Su Venkatesan, MDMK's Duralaika, the Congress party's Jothimani were among others who participated.

Meanwhile, DMK MP K Kanimozhi said the party was not completely against delimitation.

"We are not completely against delimitation. We are asking for a fair delimitation. During the election, DMK President and then CM MK Stalin had made it clear that protecting Tamil Nadu was more important than electoral victory. More than winning the election, we need to protect the rights of Tamil Nadu. That is our aim and our leader's aim," Kanimozhi said in a press conference.

The AIADMK dubbed the meeting a "hurriedly staged drama," as no new delimitation bill has been introduced in Parliament and also because there is no official announcement regarding it. Meanwhile, the Congress criticised the DMK and AIADMK for skipping the meeting despite their long history of power in the state, calling it "disappointing".

He added that markets were flooded with products from China and Vietnam and claimed demonetisation and what he called a flawed GST regime had hurt India's manufacturing sector. Small businesses in leather, textiles and automobile components, he said, had suffered and many had shut down.

The second door, he said, was entrepreneurship. "The government spoke about Startup India, but the most important requirement for starting a business is access to bank loans," he said, adding that banks were reluctant to lend to ordinary students and young entrepreneurs while large corporates received loans without moros.

He said, "In 2014, the public sector provided employment to almost half the youth, but now that number has come down to about seven lakh due to privatisation."

UP deputy CM Keshav Prasad Mishra, a post on X said, "Despite an open protest of Akhilesh Yadav and full strength of the SP-Congress alliance, Rahul Gandhi's visit was a flop show."

Gen Z was misled: Ex-min Pradhan on students' stir

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BHUBANESWAR: Former Union education minister and Samalpur MP Dharmendra Pradhan on Saturday broke his silence on his resignation and said Gen Z was misled during the protests over the NEET paper leak controversy that eventually led to his resignation. He added that he had urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to acknowledge and address the concerns of the protesters.



Dharmendra Pradhan

Speaking at a felicitation ceremony for Padma awardees in Sambalpur, Pradhan said he had met PM Modi and sought his permission to acknowledge the aspirations of the younger generation rather than allow their grievances to be exploited for political ends. "Modi agreed and later addressed the issue himself," he said.

"I have been a victim of Gen Z. For some time, the way this whole episode unfolded, I felt some people tried to mislead the children of the new generation," Pradhan said.

"I met the Prime Minister and requested him to agree to the desire of Gen Z. I told him to allow me to acknowledge responsibility from the beginning and I never sought my personal honour in the matter," he said.

"The Prime Minister accepted this, and later he himself spoke about it in front of the children," Pradhan resigned on July 25

amid weeks of student protests over the NEET paper leak controversy.

In his resignation note, he said the move was aimed at ensuring that "anti-national forces" did not exploit the agitation, that the unity of the country remained intact and that the future of students did not get "entangled in legal complexities". "It is not a matter of individual prestige for me," he had said in the note.

Pradhan had also said the government had acted immediately after irregularities were reported in the May 3 NEET-UG examination. The probe was handed to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the test was cancelled and a re-examination was conducted on June 21, with results declared on July 16.

He said he had taken responsibility from the beginning and would not allow the prospects of meritorious students to be affected by the examination system. "From the very first night, I took responsibility for this, and I never turned away from this situation," he said.

On Saturday, Pradhan said India's young population would be crucial to the country's ambition of becoming a global power.

"Every year, around two crore children are born in India. If we look at those between the ages of 15 and 25, within a period of 10 years, there will be 20 crore children of the new generation on whose shoulders India will become a global leader," Pradhan said.

His remarks come as PM Modi and Rashtriya Swamishankh Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat have stepped up efforts to engage with Gen Z, which has emerged as a major political force following the protests.

BJD's Sambalpur district president and former minister Rohit Pujari hit back at Pradhan, saying the BJP leader had been criticised over the handling of the student protests.

"Nobody had defamed Pradhan. His party and government have defamed him by police resorting to lathi-charge, tear gas and atrocities during the peaceful student agitation at Jantar Mantar. Pradhan was facing criticism because of such incidents and ultimately he resigned. He was going to lead that brought a bad name to Pradhan."

Pujari said it was the BJP government's "wrong policy" that had brought a bad name to Pradhan.



Protesters receive medical attention during an indefinite hunger strike at a protest against the Jharkhand government in Ranchi, Jharkhand, Saturday.

No headway in J'khand govt talks with students

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RANCHI: The Jharkhand government on Saturday held talks with various student outfits amid the massive agitation over alleged irregularities in the recruitment exams conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC), besides issuing an email ID seeking feedback from stakeholders, even as the protesting aspirants decided that their stir would continue until all their demands are met.

The development comes as the protest over the paper leaks entered its 15th day on Saturday. A four-member cabinet ministers' panel first met the faction of protesters led by JJKM leader Devendra Nath Mahto, whose faction is demanding a re-examination on Saturday.

They then met delegations from the Congress-backed NSUI, Advaita Chitra Sangh (ACS),

and the JMM-backed Jharkhand Chakra Manch (JCM). On Friday night, the government had held similar talks with a 10-member delegation of the JPSC/JSSC aspirants.

"The demands of the protesting aspirants are genuine," said state labour minister Sanjay Prasad Yadav, a member of the panel set up by the government, after the back-to-back meetings. Late on Saturday, the group of ministers met chief minister Hemant Soren to apprise him of the details of the series of meetings with the student groups.

Even though there was no official communication from the government side, the meeting of this report, officials aware of the matter said the government is likely to meet the first delegation once again on Sunday before taking a final call on their demands. The JCM placed five demands before and the NSUI placed six in front of the government.

HALT REMOVAL OF LOUDSPEAKERS AT MOSQUES, NCPI MP'S URGE WU CM

KOLKATA: Two NCPI MPs from West Bengal's Murshidabad district on Saturday urged Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari to stop removing mosque loudspeakers, alleging police acted overreactively. On the matter, and sought his intervention to expedite hearings of around 2.7 million people called upon from electoral rolls during 311.

The meeting with the chief minister at the secretariat here came a day after the BJP's — Murshidabad MP's Abul Kalam and Jangipuri's Khalid Rehman — attended a breakfast meeting hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi for parliamentarians from various political partners in the national capital.

Talking to reporters, Khan alleged that Muslims were being targeted in the state over the loudspeaker issue and said the rules should apply to all religious communities.

"Removing loudspeakers from mosques is extremely unfortunate for us. Removing microphones used for azaan in mosques is unprecedented since Independence. Muslims are being targeted in Bengal," he said.

He urged the government to put a stop to it, Khan said. While asserting that the court's directions to curb noise pollution must be followed, Khan said they had been told by the chief minister that around 3,800 microphones had been taken off in Bengal, valued at 1,200 tonnes. "We have requested the government to ensure that such incidents do not recur."

Soon, bill in LS for body to appoint tribunal chiefs

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NEW DELHI: A bill to set up a commission to select chairpersons and members for various tribunals following a Supreme Court direction is set to be introduced in the Lok Sabha next week.

According to the Tribunals Reforms Bill, its key aim is to improve efficiency, ensure independence, transparency and uniformity in the qualification and appointment of chairpersons and members for various tribunals. The bill also lays the framework to set up a National Tribunals Commission.

To be headquartered in the national capital, the proposed commission will consist of a chairperson and four members, of whom two will be judicial members and two technical members.

A retired Supreme Court judge or a retired chief justice of a high court will be qualified to head the proposed panel.

notes that the Supreme Court recently struck down certain provisions of the Tribunals Reforms Act, 2023, on the grounds that they are contrary to the principles of separation of powers and judicial independence and not in consonance with the earlier judicial pronouncements that have clarified the standards governing the selection and appointment of chairpersons and members of tribunals.

The top court had also directed to establish a National Tribunals Commission, which is independent, has professional expertise, and adopts a transparent process and oversight mechanism for the selection and appointment of chairpersons and members for various tribunals. Once the Bill becomes a law, the 2023 Act will stand repealed. The proposed new law also lays down qualification, manner of selection, appointment, salaries and allowances, resignation, removal and other conditions of service for the chairpersons and members of the various tribunals specified in the Bill.

[SPECIALIST HIRING RAMPED UP]

NTA creates roles to probe exam frauds

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NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) has stepped up recruitment for specialised leadership covering technology, rigour, test-centre operations; and vigilance, investigation and forensics, with the latter tasked with probing examination malpractice and coordinating with agencies such as CBI, IB, ED and state police.

In its latest advertisement notifications issued on July 25, NTA has advertised individual notifications for hiring General Manager-Test Centre Network & Operations (GM-TCNO), General Manager-Information Security (Chief Information Security Officer/CISO), and General Manager-Vigilance, Investigation & Forensics (GM-VIF) at its New Delhi headquarters.

Among the three new posts, one is tasked with leading rapid, rigorous investigation of paper leaks, impersonation and fraud.

liez said the creation of specialist positions was the first concrete step in rebuilding institutional capacity and reducing dependence on contractual and outsourced manpower.

The GM-VIF will be expected to lead "rapid, rigorous investigations" into reports of paper leaks, impersonation and fraud and build a "robust digital forensics ecosystem to trace cyber threats, analyse social-media intelligence and financial trails."

The officer will also serve as NTA's principal liaison with the CBI, IB, ED, cybercrime units and state police and travel to investi-

gation sites, partner agencies, and set up an "intelligence across India as you work demands." "If you have a distinguished background in intelligence, investigation, or anti-money laundering, IB, ED, Police, or as a CVO, this is a unique opportunity to build NTA's internal defence mechanisms and dismantle examination malpractice networks," NTA said in a post on X.

For the GM-TCNO, NTA has listed "zero-disruption exam delivery" across hundreds of centres as a key deliverable.

The officer will also expand the test-centre footprint into Tier-3, Tier-4 and aspirational districts, improve candidate facilities and coordinate with state and district administrations and law-enforcement agencies.

The GM-CISO will be tasked with architecting an "impenetrable security posture" across NTA's technology systems and operationalising a 24x7 Security Operations Centre (SOC). The post will also oversee compliance with the Digital Personal

Data Protection Act, CERT-In directives and meet deadlines and strengthen security monitoring of technology vendors.

The latest advertisements follow a series of recruitment drives last year in May/17. NTA advertised three specialist leadership positions — Chief Technology Officer (CTO), Chief Finance Officer (CFO) and General Manager Human Resources (GM-HR) — as part of efforts to modernise the agency.

On July 15, it invited applications for nine senior posts, including three joint directors, two deputy directors, two assistant directors, a research scientist and a senior superintendent (Accounts).

On July 25, NTA had also announced four newly created general manager positions covering assessment research and analytics, test-centre network and operations, information security, and vigilance, investigation and forensics, besides 16 young professional positions through the UPSC's Pratibha Setu portal.

Parl panel pushes for fee relief in Sainik Schools

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NEW DELHI: The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Defence has returned a bill to the government to make Sainik Schools more affordable and inclusive after noting that the defence ministry had "not furnished any reply or comment" on several key proposals, including extending tuition fee reimbursement, introducing scholarships for girl cadets and increasing financial support for economically weaker students.

In its report on the ministry's action taken on recommendations made in March 2026, tabled in Parliament on Friday, the panel recommended extending tuition fee reimbursement for Sainik School cadets joining the National Defence Academy (NDA) and Naval Academy (NA) from Classes 11 and 12 to Classes 9 to 12. The move would "motivate" cadets to join the NDA, NA and other defence-related establishments and "benefit" their intake, it said.

The 31-member committee, headed by BJP MP Radha Mohan Singh, also noted that the ministry had not responded to its recommendation for increasing the Centre's share in scholarship and stipend payment must be followed, government to increase its contribution "wherever possible" to students.

The panel also sought a scholarship scheme for girl cadets and asked the ministry to review its scholarship policy to encourage more girls to join the armed forces. The ministry said scholarships are currently administered by states and Union territories, with varying rates.

The committee reiterated its demand for a "strong policy" for economically weaker sections (EWS). It asked the ministry to review the Sainik Schools Society Rules & Regulations, 1997, to provide for exemption, minimisation or subsidisation of fees. Such a step, it said, "will certainly create a milestone by way of enabling deserving students get an opportunity to serve the nation."

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7-year-old girl killed, 2 hurt after being hit by school bus
JAMSHEDPUR: A seven-year-old girl was killed and two others critically injured after a school bus hit them in Jharkhand's Jamshedpur district, officials said on Saturday. The victim, Rubi Kumari, had gone with her father when the bus driver allegedly lost control of the vehicle and hit her and two others, including an 11-year-old boy, police said, adding that the bus was seized at Hurling and the driver was detained.

Pregnant woman raped on train to Bengal, 1 arrested
KOLKATA: A 20-year-old pregnant woman was allegedly raped inside the Sikim Mahananda Express on the night of August 6 when the train was nearing West Bengal's Alipurdur, adding that the accused was arrested. The accused, Gautam Mahato (30), was arrested when the train reached its destination of Alipurdur, police said, adding that he was remanded in police custody for five days.

Row as RSS body performs yajna inside JU campus
KOLKATA: A symbolic 'yajna' organised on the Jadavpur University campus by RSS-affiliated Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh (BMS) has triggered a controversy, with a teachers' association opposing the holding of religious programmes on the premises, stating it could spark competitive events by other groups. The 'yajna' was held on Friday in front of the administrative building as part of a protest against "administrative irregularities" in the university.

Maha set to clear ₹100-cr Baramati airport project

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MUMBAI: Six months after deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar died in an air crash at Baramati in Maharashtra, the state government is finalising a ₹100-crore overhaul of the small, uncontrolled airport. The Maharashtra Airport Development Company (MADC), which manages smaller airports in the state, cleared the proposal two weeks ago. Additional chief secretary (aviation) Sanjay Sehi cleared it on Wednesday and final approval is awaited from a high-power committee headed by the state chief minister.

Pawar and four others died on January 28 when the chartered Learjet 45 carrying them from Mumbai crashed as the pilot attempted to land. A preliminary probe found the aircraft executed a go-around on its first approach due to poor visibility, then made a second approach during which the pilot reported having the runway in sight but gave no read-back to air traffic control before impact. Sharda Pawar, then chief minister and now head of the opposition Nationalist Congress Party (SP), built the airport in the mid-90s to draw investment to Baramati, the family's home turf. The town turned from a rural backwater into an industrial and educational hub over the decades, but the 1,600 x 30m airstrip remained neglected, used mainly by the



Deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar and four others died in an air crash at Baramati airport in Maharashtra on January 28. HT FILE

Pawar, government officials and businesspersons. The airport is unfenced, with cattle and stray dogs wandering in. Two private flying schools operate from it, and their students staff the air traffic control unit—there are no dedicated ATC personnel. Traffic is light, at 10 to 12 VIP flights a month, but that is no excuse for the staffing gap.

Emergency services are absent. The airport has no fire tender of its own, when Pawar's aircraft crashed, one had to be summoned from the Baramati municipal council, losing precious time. The tender that arrived had no water.

The plan funds an ATC tower and a fire station, ending an arrangement in which flying school trainees handled both air traffic control and, effectively, the airport's absent emergency

response. The runway will be repaved and given a 90-metre runway-end safety area at both ends—a buffer designed to arrest aircraft that overshoot or under-shoot on landing. Other upgrades include airstrip grading, storm water drainage, a windsock, edge lights and PAPI lights (Precision Approach Path Indicator), which guide pilots to the correct descent angle. Such visual guidance is critical at an airport without an instrument landing system, where pilots rely on visual cues to judge their descent. An 8-km compound wall and an internal perimeter road are also planned.

The plan does not fund an ILS, which would let pilots land using instrument guidance in low visibility rather than visual contact with the runway. It also does not fund a night landing system; flying school

students currently install battery-operated lamps for night flying. The airport has no meteorological department and depends on Pune airport for weather information. MADC's plan is silent on this too.

Capt Sanjay Karve, former director of civil aviation with the Maharashtra government, said, "The Baramati airport runway has an inverted hump and this must be corrected during repaving. PAPI is the easiest and cheapest way to let crew know of glide flow in case of bad weather. DGCA must ask for PAPI for all uncontrolled airports."

Karve was sceptical about the political will to see the revamp through. "Upgrading it now is like locking the stable after the horse has bolted. The moment Sunetra Pawar is no longer deputy chief minister, Baramati airport will be forgotten. Take Karad airport, for instance. The moment Prithviraj Chavan ceased to be CM, the project took a back seat. Latour airport was forgotten after Vilasrao Deshmukh ceased to be CM and became a Union minister. Nanded airport took a back seat after Ashok Chavan lost power. In essence, we don't have a long-term plan for aviation."

Mihir Bhagavi, president of the Bombay Flying Club, said, "These changes should have been made long ago and implemented at all MADC airports. They are the bare minimum requirements for any airport."

SC collegium to recommend 5 new high court chief justices

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court collegium has decided to recommend five judges for appointment as chief justices of different high courts, in a move aimed at filling several vacancies that have left courts functioning under acting chief justices, people aware of the matter said on Saturday.

The collegium, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and comprising justices Vilram Nath and BV Nagarathna, has decided to recommend Delhi high court judge Justice V Kameswar Rao as chief justice of the Patna high court.

It has also decided to recommend two acting chief justices for appointment as full-time chief justices of their respective high courts—Justice Ashwini Kumar Mishra for the Punjab and Haryana high court and Justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma for the Rajasthan high court.

The collegium has further decided to recommend Alakhnagar high court judge Justice Mahesh Chandra Tripathi as chief justice of the Bombay high court and Bombay high court's acting chief justice Justice Ravindra Vi-

THE COLLEGIUM IS YET TO APPOINT FULL-TIME CHIEF JUSTICES FOR THE HIGH COURTS OF MADHYA PRADESH, JAMMU & KASHMIR AND LADAKH

hadraro Ghuge as full-time chief justice of the Calcutta high court. The signed recommendations are expected to be sent to the Union government shortly, people familiar with the matter said.

No decision has, however, been taken so far on appointing full-time chief justices for the Madhya Pradesh high court and the high court of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh.

The move comes against the backdrop of several high courts functioning under acting chief justices. According to the position as on August 1, the Bombay high court has been headed by Justice Ghuge as acting chief justice since June 2, 2026, while the Calcutta high court has been under acting chief justice Justice Tapabrata Chakraborty since June 21. The Madhya Pradesh and Jammu &

Kashmir and Ladakh high courts have also had acting chief justices since June 2.

The Punjab and Haryana high court has been headed by Justice Ashwini Kumar Mishra as acting chief justice since June 2, while Justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma has been acting chief justice of the Rajasthan high court since September 28, 2025. Patna, too, was shown as being headed by an acting chief justice in the August 1 position chart.

The recommendations would therefore provide full-time leadership to five of these courts, leaving Madhya Pradesh and Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh without permanent chief justices for the time being.

The recommendations are also significant in view of the impending changes in the higher judiciary. The Supreme Court currently has three vacancies. Two more vacancies are scheduled to arise later this year with the retirement of Justice Sanjay Karol on August 22 and Justice Satish Chandra Sharma on November 29.

Justice Karol was elevated to the Supreme Court on February 6, 2023, while Justice Sharma joined the apex court on November 9, 2023.

Spain set to replace India envoy

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: The Spanish government has begun the process of replacing its ambassador to India, Juan Antonio March, following complaints about allegedly organising cultural events at great expense without clearance from the foreign ministry, according to a media report. March was appointed as the envoy to India in September 2024 and is expected to be replaced within a few weeks. The Objective, a Spanish digital daily newspaper, reported, citing its sources.

The Spanish government, at the request of foreign minister Jose Manuel Albares, has sent a communication to the Indian side for an agreement or formal understanding for appointing Alfredo Martinez Serrano, currently envoy to Canada, as the new ambassador in New Delhi.

March has been at the centre of a controversy since reports emerged earlier this year that he was planning to organise concerts in Rajasthan, featuring STEM Dance Kampi of Bengaluru and the tenors Joan Lainez and Zhu Hailing, that were to have coincided with the ambassador's birthday. The objective reported these concerts were being organised "without the approval of his superiors in Madrid". Spanish authorities subsequently vetoed the cultural events proposed by March.

Opposition lawmakers and UGT, a major Spanish trade union, have called for the ambassador's dismissal. Spain's Anti-Corruption Prosecutor's Office received a report in May from a foreign ministry official that said certain details regarding the ambassador, which "if true, could have criminal relevance in the area of public procurement and the management

of funds", it reported.

Last year, Zhu, who has dual Chinese and German nationality, received €18,000 from the Spanish embassy in New Delhi for concerts organised by March, according to the media report. Zhu was hired for two concerts in New Delhi and Kathmandu in July, and another in Bhutan in October, when the ambassador went to present his credentials.

In a series of reports earlier this year, The Objective detailed how the matter had come to light after the Spanish embassy's cultural attaché sent a report to Madrid on plans to raise funds for concerts in 2026 without informing the foreign ministry. The hiring of Zhu, who lives in China, stood out as Spanish embassies are obligated to promote the country's culture with Spanish artists or local performers who have artistic ties to Spain, the reports said.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

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It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.

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HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

Go strait, take a left, find the clues, finish the quiz

Sports, stunts and videogames about sports and stunts; music, movies, TV shows, and even global trade. There's a mixed bag of new in this quiz. Go on, give it a go...



Natasha Rego

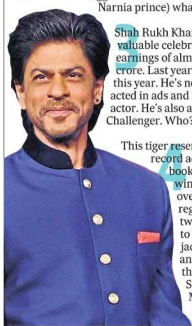


Kazakhstan now has an Amur tiger. Name the native species that went extinct

REUTERS

IF SRK is India's most valuable celebrity, who is #3?

The first amur tiger in 70 years was released in Kazakhstan. The country used to be home to its own subspecies of tiger, before it was hunted to extinction. Named after the biggest lake in the Caucasus (and a Narnia prince) what was it called?



Shah Rukh Khan is India's most valuable celebrity, with total earnings of almost Rs 1,700 crore. Last year's top spot is #3 this year. He's not an actor, but he's acted in ads and is married to an actor. He's also a die-hard Royal Challenger. Who?

South Korean Police have raided the HQ of this coffee chain after public outrage over its Liberation Day ads. They evoked painful memories of a brutal military crackdown on pro-democracy protesters in 1980. A problem of Venti proportions. Which chain?

Down Dalt has been a stunt performer for 15 years. She became famous when the actor she recently doubled for said she had "the greatest arms". She stood in for Odysseus to make the giant Laestrygonians appear even bigger. Who gave her the shoutout?

This tiger reserve has received record advance bookings for the winter season – over 40,000 registrations in two hours. Expect to see hyenas, jackals and desert animals too. Name the destination in Sawai Madhopur, Rajasthan.

Answers on page 06

7 dead as pvt bus skids off HP road

Shailee Dogra

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SHIMLA: Seven people were killed and 11 others injured after a private bus skidded off the road, overturned and crashed onto a lower stretch of the Bairaigarh-Tissa road in Himachal Pradesh's Chamba district on Saturday, said police.

The deceased were identified as Jagdeep Sharma (50), Dinesh (35), Jagde (24) and Hardi (45), all from Bahla village; Tej Singh (30) from Satyas village; Neelam (34) from Devikothi village; and bus driver Rup Singh (35) from Chilli village.

The bus was en route to Chamba from Bairaigarh when the incident took place near Chalmi Mor.

The 27-kilometre Bairaigarh-Tissa road is known for its narrow paths and steep drops. It serves as a key stretch on the way to the high-altitude Sach Pass.

Chamba superintendent of police (SP) Vijay Sakani said the cause of the accident was under investigation. After police arrived at the site following a tip-off, those injured were shifted to nearby health facilities. Six people in critical condition were later referred to Pt



The overturned private bus at the site of the accident in Chamba district on Saturday.

Jawaharal Nehru Government Medical College and Hospital in Chamba for specialised medical care, said police.

A multi-agency rescue and relief operation was launched following the accident. In addition to locals, personnel from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), state police, Home Guard, fire services and the revenue department were involved.

President Droupadi Murmu expressed grief over the loss of lives in the accident and conveyed her condolences to the families of the deceased. She also prayed for the speedy recovery of those injured.

Chief minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu also expressed his condolences and said the district administration was

ordered to ensure that all injured passengers were immediately admitted to the nearest hospitals and provided proper treatment.

Officials said the accident added to the growing toll from disasters and road accidents reported across the state during the monsoon. Data shows that the state recorded 66 disaster-related deaths and 86 road accident deaths between June 30 to August 8, with Lahaul and Spiti logging 14 disaster-related deaths, the highest in the state.

Monsoon-related disasters have also left 2 people missing and 240 injured, while 197 live-stock animals have been reported dead, said officials.

Assam flood toll hits 99, 147k still affected

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

GUWAHATI: The death toll in Assam's flood-hit districts rose to 99 on Saturday after more deaths were reported in Charaideo and Golaghat districts, officials said on Saturday. The state government will launch an assessment of the damage from Sunday to expedite release of rehabilitation funds, they added.

The Assam Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) bulletin said the latest fatalities were reported from Golaghat district.

The bulletin said 12 districts of Sonitpur, Nagaon, Golaghat, Jorhat, Sivasagar, Hojai, Darrang, Jorhat, Dhemaji, Charaideo, Karbi Anglong, Lakhimpur and Bishwanth remained affected by the deluge.

The number of affected population was at 1,47,576, with Golaghat being the worst-hit at 61,735 people continued to reel under the deluge, followed by Sivasagar (43,492) and Jorhat (24,283).

The administration was operating 53 relief camps, sheltering

8,568 displaced people. Another 41 relief distribution centres are also functional.

A crop area of 10,599.89 hectares remained submerged. The ASDMA bulletin said the Dhanisi (S) was flowing above the danger level at Golaghat, Numaligarh, and Kushiara at Sribhumi.

Damage to various infrastructure, including houses and roads, was reported from the affected districts.

Chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Friday said his government will conduct a door-to-door assessment of flood damage in the worst-hit districts of Jorhat, Sivasagar, Golaghat and Charaideo from August 9 to 30. The assessments, road, grazing household will be left out and the government will provide maximum relief permissible and added that after the first assessment list is compiled, it will be reviewed with the affected families. "Once we have the estimate of the funds, we can start providing the requisite financial assistance for permanent rehabilitation," said the chief minister.

Panel seeks study on climate crisis-forest fires' link

Jasjeev Gandhiok and Prawesh Lama

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NEW DELHI: A Parliamentary Standing Committee on Environment has recommended a region-specific study to establish the link between climate change and the frequency and intensity of forest fires in the Himalayan region.

In its report on 'Forest Fires in the Himalayan Region', tabled in the Lok Sabha on Friday, the committee also asked the ministry to develop a centralised database recording forest fire-related human casualties and compensation paid by governments.

The committee said forest fires have emerged as a major environmental challenge, particularly in the Himalayan region, where "changing climatic conditions, prolonged dry spells, and

anthropogenic pressures have altered their frequency and intensity." It said fires pose growing environmental and ecological risks across the region.

"Such a study should, at a minimum, examine long-term trends in temperature, precipitation and dryspell duration against historical forest fire incidence data; assess how altitudinal and species-wise variation across Himalayan forest types affects fire vulnerability under changing climatic conditions; and generate predictive fire-risk models that can inform seasonal preparedness, resource deployment and early-warning systems," the Committee recommended in its 42nd report.

The committee also flagged the absence of a centralised database for forest fire victims, saying the lack of a national record obscures the human cost of fires.

THE COMMITTEE HAS FLAGGED THE ABSENCE OF A CENTRALISED DATABASE ON VICTIMS OF FOREST FIRES

"In the absence of a consolidated national record, the true human cost of forest fires across states remains obscured, hampering both accountability and evidence-based policy formulation. The Committee, therefore, recommends that the Ministry take urgent steps, in consultation with state governments, to develop and maintain a centralised database capturing details of forest fire casualties and compensation paid, to enable systematic monitoring and

informed policy interventions," the report stated.

The panel called for separate fire mitigation plans for the western and eastern Himalayan regions, citing differences in climate and human factors. It said fires in the west were driven by pre-monsoon heat, pine-needle fuel loads and human ignition, while those in the east were influenced by dry conditions and cultivation-related burning.

"This demonstrates that a uniform, pan-Himalayan approach to fire prevention and mitigation would be inadequate to the distinct ecological and socio-economic realities of the two regions. The Committee is, therefore, of the opinion that mitigation and adaptation strategies must be tailored specific to each region," the report stated.

Uttarakhand emerged as the

most fire-affected state in 2020-21 and 2023-24. The committee attributed this to Chir pine forests, pine-needle accumulation, dry pre-monsoon weather, steep slopes, forest-fringe settlements, road grazing and human ignition sources. "The repeated high fire counts in Uttarakhand indicate a need for intensive fuel-load management, pine-needle utilization, community-based fire prevention and rapid response systems," it said.

On the same day, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Home Affairs, in its report submitted to the Rajya Sabha, recommended improving and uniformly implementing Heat Action Plans across heat-prone states and cities, along with green cover, cool roofs, shaded public spaces, water access and medical preparedness.

Shah visits temple in TN



Union home minister Amit Shah offered prayers at the Arunligu Arunachaleswarar Temple in Tamil Nadu on Saturday. On Sunday, Shah is scheduled to preside over a government event in neighbouring Puducherry and present the President's colours to the Puducherry police.

HT PHOTO

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



Sunday Hindustan Times

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors indeed who longer tread a homely quiet valley but sea walls, and each appear in a Himalai village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out.

Answers to the quiz are on page 06. The quiz is a fun way to test your knowledge of the week's events. It includes clues about various topics, including sports, music, movies, and global trade. The quiz is designed to be challenging and fun. The answers are provided at the end of the quiz. The quiz is a great way to spend your Sunday. It is a fun and engaging way to learn about the world. The quiz is a great way to test your knowledge of the week's events. It includes clues about various topics, including sports, music, movies, and global trade. The quiz is designed to be challenging and fun. The answers are provided at the end of the quiz. The quiz is a great way to spend your Sunday. It is a fun and engaging way to learn about the world.

ROW ERUPTS OVER LOCAL TRINAMOOL LEADER'S DEATH IN POLICE CUSTODY

KOLKATA:

A political storm erupted in West Bengal after a local Trinamool Congress leader allegedly died in police custody at Halishahar in North 24 Parganas on Saturday.

The deceased, Birju Keot, was the husband of Jenny Sharma Keot, co-councillor of Kanchrapara Municipality. Police said he was arrested on August 1 and booked under BNS sections relating to cheating, assault, and a woman's modesty and the Arms Act.

"On Friday night my husband was beaten up mercilessly inside the police station. His hands and feet were tied... Blood had oozed out of his ears. There were multiple injury marks on his back," Keot told media.

Police, however, refuted the charge. "He suddenly fell ill in the morning. He was rushed to the JNM Hospital in Nadia where doctors declared him dead. An enquiry by a judicial magistrate has been ordered," said an officer.

TMC's Abhishek Banerjee said on X: "His name was not in the FIR. He was still picked up by @WBPolice. He died in custody."

Bipjur BJP MLA Sudipto Das said, "There were multiple allegations against him... Actually, the family is used to the TMC culture in which police was asked to implicate innocent people in false cases. I am ready to extend all help to the family if they need".

GOVT: NO CHARGES FOR UPI USERS, VAST MAJORITY TO REMAIN FREE

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union government on Saturday categorically stated that consumers and small merchants will continue to enjoy free Unified Payments Interface (UPI) services to allay fears regarding the levy of charges on such transactions following the passage of a Bill to amend the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007.

However, nominal Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) for merchants will be applicable as and when charges are introduced. "They will apply only to a limited set of merchant transactions, above a certain threshold, at a nominal rate, far lower than debit or credit card MDRs," the finance ministry said.

The statement comes two days after Lok Sabha passed a Bill to amend the 2007 Act which authorises the Centre to permit banks and other service providers to levy charges on payments made through UPI and other notified electronic payment modes.

"Once the Parliament passes the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which proposes to amend Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the UPI and Payments Steering Committee" headed by NPCI will decide on the MDR, it said. "The statement will be issued by the ministry."



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Choksi's extradition still under review: Belgian govt

Neeraj Chauhan
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Four months after a court in Antwerp ruled that fugitive diamondaire Mehul Choksi can be extradited to India, the concerned Belgian ministry supposed to take a call on his repatriation is sitting on the decision and has said the matter is "still under examination".

"The decision issued by the Indictment Chamber of the Antwerp Court of Appeal in April was an advisory opinion and did not constitute a final decision on the extradition request. The case is still under examination. At

this stage, we are unable to provide any further information or comment," said Sharon Beavis, spokesperson for the Belgian justice minister, Annelies Verlinde, in an email to HT.

Indian officials said the delay was unwarranted as they had already established a strong case with foolproof evidence against Choksi, based on which Antwerp court ruled that there is an applicable legal base to extradite the fugitive diamondaire to India.

"In any extradition case, the final decision is ultimately of the government of that country. We are waiting for the Belgian government to approve his extradition," said an officer, who asked not to be named.

On April 3 this year, an Antwerp court of appeal rendered an advice towards the Belgian government concerning the request made by the Indian



Mehul Choksi

tion," said an officer, who asked not to be named.

On April 3 this year, an Antwerp court of appeal rendered an advice towards the Belgian government concerning the request made by the Indian

authorities for the extradition of Mehul Choksi, based on the allegation of having committed the crimes of fraud, criminal conspiracy and forgery between December 31, 2016 and January 1, 2019 in India.

The court had also rejected Choksi's claims that he was being targeted due to political reasons.

Choksi, 65, is held in a prison in Antwerp following his arrest on April 11 last year at India's request. Indian investigators have accused Choksi of six bank frauds between 2018 and 2022 involving amounts totalling nearly ₹13,000 crore.

His extradition was sought under Indian Penal Code (IPC) sections 120 B (criminal conspiracy), 201 (destruction of evidence), 409 (criminal breach of trust), 420 (cheating), 477 A (falsification of accounts), and sections 7 and 13 (bribery) of the Prevention of Corruption Act; which are crimes in Belgium as well under the dual criminality clause of the extradition treaty.

The United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (UNTOC) and United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC) were also invoked in the extradition request.

HILSA IN GANGA

parts of the Ganga-Yamuna system.

Hilsa spend much of their adult life in the sea and along coastal waters before entering rivers to breed. This adaptability has helped the fish survive and fend off the adverse impacts of shifting aquatic conditions.

But that cycle was shattered after the Farakka Barrage opened in 1975. Changes in river flow, obstruction of migration, pollution, habitat degradation and increasing human pressure together contributed to the disappearance of hilsa from large portions of the upper and middle Ganga.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

Delhi, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh to all implement and consider recommendations submitted in an earlier report by the ICAR-CIFRI, which listed measures which could be adopted to stem the count of exotic species in the river.

HT on August 6 also reported the Upper Yamuna River Board (UYRB) asked Delhi, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh to develop "fish ladders" at the Wazirabad, Okhla and Hathnoid barrages respectively to allow native fish species in the river to migrate. A fish ladder is a stepped water structure that helps fish bypass obstacles – such as dams and barrages – during their migration upstream.

ment at Delhi University, said the discovery was only a start.

"Hilsa are migratory fish, which migrate upstream to breed. The barrage-altered water flows in the river and the pollution and habitat degradation have disrupted hilsa migration into the upper Ganga. Hilsa can travel hundreds of kilometres upstream. But breeding in freshwater is the most important. Two fish do not prove population recovery. True restoration would require evidence of natural migration, spawning, survival and successful reproduction," she said, calling for sustained monitoring.

"Evidence of natural breeding will eventually determine whether hilsa is genuinely reclaiming its historic migration route," she added.

CM assures Pant of help in acquiring U'khand plot

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

DEHRADUN: Chief minister Pushkar Singh Dhami on Saturday responded positively to cricketer Rishabh Pant's appeal for help to acquire land to re-settle in Uttarakhand.

Taking to X, he said he has directed officials concerned to assist the cricketer as per rules.

"Your love for your motherland and your desire to return here and contribute is highly commendable. Regarding the matter raised by you, the concerned officials are being directed. They will contact you soon and ensure all possible assistance as per the rules".

Speaking to reporters separately, Dhami said Pant has brought recognition to both Uttarakhand and the country.

"Rishabh Pant is from our state. He has brought glory to the country and the state. He is welcome here. Our officials will discuss everything with him. If he requires anything, we will certainly provide it," he said.

Pant's appeal came in a late-night X post. He asked for help to navigate the land acquisition process in Uttarakhand and expressed a desire to "shift his base" back from Delhi.

"It's a long time for me, especially being local from Uttarakhand. I have been trying to buy land to shift my base from Delhi to Uttarakhand and I couldn't find anything facilitating and big to live here. I love my Uttarakhand," Pant wrote.

He requested Dhami to allow him to purchase land from the government to build his first house in his home state.

1 DEAD AFTER BEING HIT BY CAR IN J&K DYCM'S CAVALCADE

JAMMUR: A man was killed after being hit by a vehicle reportedly part of the cavalcade of Jammu and Kashmir deputy chief minister Surinder Choudhary while the vehicles were returning after dropping the leader at his residence in Jammu on Saturday, officials said.

The deceased was identified as Bharat, a resident of Bihar, who was crossing the road when he was struck by the vehicle at Gangyal on the outskirts of the city, the officials said.

The officials said that the victim sustained critical injuries and died while being shifted to the hospital by the vehicle's driver and accompanying security personnel.

An FIR was registered at the concerned police station following the accident and further details are awaited, the officials added.

Five Indians on board tanker hit near Strait

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MUMBAI: A projectile reportedly struck a Liberian-flagged crude oil tanker MT FRANCE C with five Indian sailors on board on Saturday after it crossed the Strait of Hormuz while proceeding west-bound.

All 5 Indians on board have been confirmed to be safe.

A report by the Directorate of Maritime Administration said that four incidents involving Indian-flagged vessels and 35 incidents involving foreign-flagged vessels with Indian crew were reported during the West Asia conflict so far, including 9 confirmed fatalities, 10 injured and one presumed dead.

Seven Indian vessels are currently in Persian Gulf (West of Strait of Hormuz), with 153 Indian seafarers on board, it said.

A total of 10 vessels of Indian interest, including both Indian-flagged and foreign-flagged vessels bound for India, remain in the Persian Gulf (west of the Strait of Hormuz) and have been identified for evacuation.

A total of 4091 seafarers have been evacuated by various shipping companies as of Saturday, said the report.

SEVEN INDIAN VESSELS ARE CURRENTLY IN THE PERSIAN GULF WITH 153 INDIAN SAILORS ON BOARD

rently in Persian Gulf (West of Strait of Hormuz), with 153 Indian seafarers on board, it said.

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Barrage that stonewalled their journey

Farakka was built primarily to divert water towards the Hooghly river in West Bengal to improve navigation and maintain the river's navigability near Kolkata. At the same time, it reshaped the ecology of its waters.

For hilsa, the problem was particularly acute. Unlike fish that can complete their life cycle within a limited stretch of water, hilsa requires open channels between the marine environment and freshwater spawning grounds.

Scientists have regarded the species as an important indicator of river health because its presence depends on several ecological dovetailing – adequate flow, suitable dissolved oxygen, appropriate temperature and accessible breeding habitats.

The Ghazipur finding also comes in the backdrop of attempts to rebuild the lost hilsa population. In January, the National Green Tribunal (NGT) issued directions to Delhi and other states along the Yamuna to restore native fish populations and control exotic species in the river as a priority.

The January 29 order asked

Ranching gives the Ganga another chance

CIFRI and NMCG have been working on hilsa conservation through a combination of fish ranching, tagging, monitoring and habitat-related interventions. Ranching is the practice of breeding fish in controlled environments before releasing them into open waters.

Earlier experiments have provided encouraging evidence, said experts involved in the project. Tagged hilsa released near Farakka have been detected hundreds of kilometres away, including in Uttar Pradesh. But scientists urged caution and underlined that last week's sighting was not a reliable barometer of success.

Himanshu Thakkar, Coordinator at South Asia Network on Dams, Rivers & People (SANDRP) said a more positive indicator would be if the fish were to breed and "complete a life cycle or two".

"At present, other evidence – including water quality parameters through government data related to the river shows the water's increasingly deteriorating situation," he said.

Neeta Sehgal, senior professor (fish biology) at the zoology depart-

MODI SPEAKS TO VANCE

ments, it said without going into details.

They "reaffirmed their commitment to further strengthening cooperation in trade, defence, critical and emerging technologies, energy security and critical minerals".

The phone call came against the backdrop of continuing negotiations between India and the US to conclude an interim bilateral trade agreement and differences over the tariff policies of the Trump administration. Modi has also spoken to President Donald Trump on the phone several times this year, and the two leaders met on the margins of the G7 Summit in France in June.

Modi said in his social media post that he had congratulated Vance and Second Lady Usha Vance "on the birth of their son and conveyed best wishes to the entire family".

Vance and Usha announced the birth of their fourth child – Alec Neal Vance – on July 19. This is the first child born to a sitting US vice president in more than 150 years.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

NEW DELHI SUNDAY JANUARY 22, 2023

HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors, leaders who no longer lead. A busy green walks her last walk, and cracks appear in a Himalayan village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out.

Answer: Reshma Kapoor is the author of the children's book *Black Alice and Speckles Jammy*. Who actually wore and wore and wore?

Answer: Rishi is not an author or filmmaker, but the "venerable" Alice and Speckles is a character whose whimsical adventures have won over 400 copies since their launch in November. In December, the character was featured in a book titled *Black Alice and Speckles*. Last week she said, "You can see your own world and imagination."

Answer: Rishi is a popular character and was widely loved. Her last walk, and cracks appear in a Himalayan village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out.

Answer: Rishi is a popular character and was widely loved. Her last walk, and cracks appear in a Himalayan village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out.

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REFLECTIONS

{ THE BIG PICTURE }

Putting people at the heart of Parliament's performance

Increased public consultation and post-legislative assessment of laws can make the legislative process more inclusive and responsive

The word 'parliament' traces its origin to the French word *parler*, which means 'to speak'. In April, during a discussion in the Lok Sabha on increasing the number of Lok Sabha seats, BJP MP Tejasi Surya and Congress MP Shashi Tharoor highlighted the need to increase opportunities for interventions in Parliament. However, irrespective of the issue of numbers, enabling more focused interventions by parliamentarians needs conscious efforts to reform the procedures of Parliament.

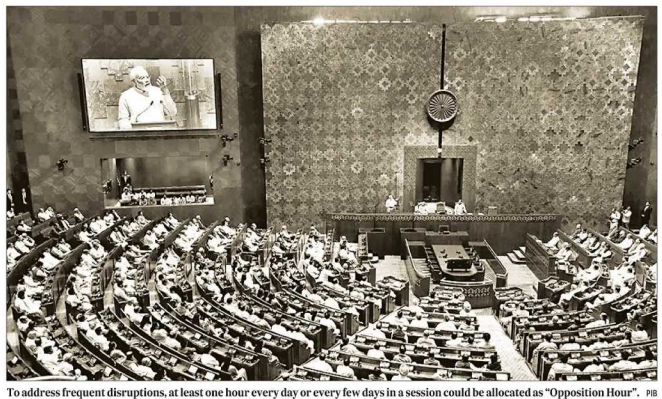
Public expectations from legislators mostly tend towards 'getting things done', i.e., administration work — particularly at a constituency level. Limited attention is paid to interventions they make on the floor of the House. Recently, during the Tamil Nadu assembly elections, debates focused on the alleged lack of development in the constituency of an incumbent minister. It is unfortunate that MLAs, MPs and MPs are expected to do the same job as that of a councillor/ward member entrusted with local governance and are often assessed on 'development works' in their respective constituencies as opposed to their performance in the respective Houses. This partly explains why initiatives tracking parliamentary performances of MPs and assembly performances of MLAs have not received the kind of public support they deserve.

BR Ambedkar, during the Constituent Assembly debates, hoped that the frequency at which future legislatures met would make legislators tired. While the first Lok Sabha (1952-57) managed to sit frequently, with an average annual sitting of 135 days, the 18th Lok Sabha (June 2024-present) has met on 135 days over three years — a yearly average of 67 days. MPs from all parties have advocated a minimum of 120 days of sittings annually with a tentative schedule to help them better prepare for the sessions. Instead of an 11 am start, House proceedings could start at 10 am, allowing more time for Zero and Question Hours. More starred and unstarred questions should be allowed while facilitating increased transparency in balloting and listing of questions. To address frequent disruptions, procedures could be suitably amended to allocate at least one hour every day or every few days in a session at 'Opposition Hour', where the Opposition sets the agenda, prioritising matters requiring a response from the executive. We could emulate the UK's and Canada's parliaments which allocate 20 and 22 days a year to the Opposition, respectively.

To reduce friction between MPs and promote civility in public discourse, the practice of Treasury and Opposition MPs being seated separately could also be discontinued. Ultimately, they are not enemies, and their political rivalry should not be considered during the allocation of seats. From a lawmakers' point of view, all bills reaching Parliament should be subject to public consultation during the drafting stage and by committees during scrutiny stage. Decisions in Parliament should be driven by consultation, consensus, and concurrence. Essentially, copies of the bills featuring in

the session's tentative list of business should be handed out as the list gets published to enable more effective and informed discussions upon their introduction. After introduction, all these bills should mandatorily be referred to the Standing Committees, similar to what happens in Kerala — however with more time than is usual in the Kerala instance, to ensure detailed scrutiny. Private member bills, initiated by non-minister MPs, seldom get noticed, especially because this happens on alternative Friday afternoons when attendance is low. Only around 2-3% of the hundreds of private members' bills introduced in Parliament are taken up for discussion, and several parliamentary sessions have ended without any private members' business having been transacted. A conscious effort should be made to increase the time allocation for private members' business during the week, to encourage policy endocues by MPs. Procedural interventions should also ensure that at least one-third of the private member bills gets discussed, with the concerned minister's attendance made mandatory.

Committees, known as mini-parliaments, while allowing flexibility to scrutinise matters of public importance, suffer from structural weaknesses. Most consultative committees have not met even once, against the mandatory requirement to hold at least four meetings a year. The tenure of department-related parliamentary standing committees should be increased to at least two years to ensure their sustained and effective working. In addition to the staff deployed from the parliament secretariat, there should be a provision for the appointment of external experts as advisors to the committees. The committees' interactions with external



To address frequent disruptions, at least one hour every day or every few days in a session could be allocated as "Opposition Hour".

stakeholders should be broadcast and submissions should be made publicly available. A verbatim record of evidence tendered before committees must be made public alongside committee reports.

Standing committees must also assess the impact of laws, facilitating strong post-legislative scrutiny. Mandatory post-legislative scrutiny should be undertaken by the standing committees five years after the passage of a bill. Committees should allow the public to also deposit before them. For example, select committees of the Kerala legislature regularly host public hearings in district court-lectures, allowing the public to participate in the process. Parliamentary committees could also consider a non-Parliament venue where the public gets to appear before them.

During discussions on salaries and allowances in 2010, then Rajya Sabha MP NK Singh emphasised the need to have qualified researchers to support MPs in performing their duties. Many public officials below the protocol rank of MP have personal staff,

funded by the government, for support in daily work. The parliament secretariat currently gives only ₹40,000 a month to a Lok Sabha MP to appoint one computer-literate staff member; this research support gap is serious and needs to be bridged by allowing every MP to hire two-three research staff whose salaries are borne by the parliament secretariat. This will elevate the quality of discourse and interventions in Parliament, making it an investment in improved legislative quality.

Recently, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla emphasised the importance of public participation in a parliamentary democracy. Parliament should also evolve more ways in which citizens interact with its proceedings. States such as Kerala and Tamil Nadu are contemplating how citizens can raise issues directly in the state legislative assembly. The parliament website should have a dedicated citizen's corner. Apart from simple explanations on the working of Parliament and process flow for visiting Parliament, the

section should clearly explain how citizens could get to know the work of their MP, interact with MPs and committees, and submit petitions. In the interest of inclusivity, broadcasting of parliamentary proceedings in sign language could also be considered.

As the chair of International IDEA (Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance) for the year 2026, India should proactively implement the institute's eight principles of parliamentary public engagement. *Global Parliamentary Reports*, published by the Inter-Parliamentary Union and UNDP, also offer important insights into meeting public expectations, improving oversight, and facilitating effective public participation. These should essentially act as the guiding principles for our legislatures in shaping the 21st century reforms.

Arun PS, co-founder and research lead of Aayati Research, a law and policy think tank.

The views expressed are personal

{ SUNDAY SENTIMENTS }

Karan Thapar



An Indian dynasty almost inherited the Caliphate

Sometimes, more interesting than actual history is what you could call 'what if' history. It's often referred to as counterfactual story-telling. A delightful book I have just read states that somewhere between a what-if account and a realisation that it almost did happen. In fact, it seems the cast of characters involved — the *dramatis personae*, you could call them — wanted it to happen. But it did not.

I am referring to the little known fact that in the 1930s, after the Turkish government abolished the caliphate, serious efforts were made to pass it onto the family of the Nizam of Hyderabad. Had that happened the centuries old caliphate, that stretched back 1300 years, could have become an Indian institution.

This amazing story is the riveting subject of Imran Mulla's excellent book, *The Indian Caliphate: Desires Ottomans and the Billionaire Prince*. Let me offer you a brief, edited account.

Let's start with Shaukati Ali of the Ali

brothers and the Khalifat Movement of the 1920s. When he became aware that the last Caliph, Abdumjid, was living in impecunious exile on the French Riviera, he persuaded the seventh Nizam of Hyderabad, Mir Asaf-ud-Daula, to support him. Not much later he arranged a marital union between the Ottoman and Asaf Jah families. The Nizam's eldest grandson and, later, heir, Mir Himayat Ali Khan — better known as Prince Asaf Jah — was chosen to marry the last Caliph's daughter, Princess Durrusshahvar. The Hyderabad groom was 24. The Turkish bride 18. At the same time, Asaf Jah's younger brother, Mir Shujaat Ali Khan — known as Prince Moazzam Jah — was betrothed to a junior Turkish princess, Niloufer.

The joint wedding ceremony was held at the Palais Carababel on 12 November 1931. Mulla writes: "Both princes wore richly-embroidered robes of Indian cloth, with turbans on their heads and garlands of flowers hung around their necks in the normal Indian way... Locals practically

besieged the Palais Carababel, fascinated by the prospect of an exotic Islamic wedding. Asaf Jah and Moazzam Jah drove from the Negresco (their hotel) to the villa, each in their own convertible Mercedes — both cars white, Hyderabad's princely colour, and covered in flowers. Large hooters were placed on the front of each and hooted all the way to the villa."

The wedding was a small affair. Mulla says, and Abdumjid, the Caliph, personally conducted it. Negotiations over the financial settlement continued through the ceremony. Hyderabad's two princes knelt for more than 30 minutes before propped up pictures of their brides. Eventually, the contract was signed. With aching knees, they rose at last. The brides donned their veils and there were several rounds of phos. Afterwards, there was a small tea party.

Now this was a time when Abdumjid was desperate to secure the continuation of the caliphate. There were many who wanted the title, including King Fuad of Egypt. But it seems the wife Shaukati Ali persuaded Abdumjid to bestow it upon the eldest child from the union of Asaf Jah and Durrusshahvar. That is to say his grandson, Abdumjid, Mulla suggests, was rather enamoured of the idea. Its appeal was significantly enhanced by the Nizam's legendary fortune. The impoverished caliph needed money. It was skint!

Mulla writes of an alleged deed between the two houses to seal the arrangement, but gamely admits it was inauthentic. However, he argues both

IN THE 1930S, AFTER THE TURKISH GOVERNMENT ABOLISHED THE CALIPHATE, SERIOUS EFFORTS WERE MADE TO PASS IT ONTO THE FAMILY OF THE NIZAM OF HYDERABAD. HAD THAT HAPPENED, THE CENTURIES-OLD CALIPHATE COULD HAVE BECOME AN INDIAN INSTITUTION

wanted the outcome it intended. It would not have united the Ottoman and Asaf Jah families in the history and tradition of the caliphate, but it would also have rooted the institution in Indian soil and given an unprecedented importance to Indian Islam. But it was not to be. The British were not in favour.

However, proof of this tale is that in Khuldabad, which used to be part of old Hyderabad, Mir Osman Ali Khan, who was still Nizam when Abdumjid died, built an Ottoman-style mausoleum to house the last Caliph's mortal remains. He wanted to be buried in India. But that too was not to be.

Karan Thapar is the author of *Devil's Advocate: The Untold Story*. The views expressed are personal

{ ENGENDER }

Lalita Panicker



Fostering safe motherhood with institutional deliveries

In many parts of the country, especially in those which are remote and with restricted access to medical facilities, home births have been considered something of a tradition, even as they increased the risks to maternal and neonatal health, with greater chances of postpartum haemorrhage, infections, and delays in emergency care. For some years now, a quiet change has been taking place across many states. In Bihar, just two years ago, more than 40% of deliveries in 80 panchayats across 18 districts took place at home. Today, those same panchayats are leading from the front with institutional deliveries becoming the accepted standard of care. This has come about because of the government's home delivery-free panchayat campaign.

Dr Meena Samant, director of obstetrics and gynaecology, Medanta, says, "Proper management of emergency complications arising during childbirth is possible only in modern medical facilities. Bihar's home-delivery-free model demonstrates that the synergy between social behaviour change and health services can effectively reduce maternal mortality rates."

The state health department recognised that this was not just a medical issue but a social one. It thus targeted behaviour change, orienting ASHAs, ANMs, CHOs, and facilitators to engage directly with communities. Coordinated arrangements at the panchayat level tracked pregnant women, monitored probable delivery dates and provided timely access to the health institutions. Areas where home deliveries once exceeded 40% have seen these drops to 58.5%.

Muzaffarpur district has emerged as the most compelling example, where home deliveries have fallen to just 2% across 19 panchayats. "We went door-to-door to explain to every household that delivery in the hospital is safe for both mother and child," says Vibha Kumari, head of Bagha Khal panchayat. Today, no deliveries take

place at home in her village. Dr Sudhir Kumar, civil surgeon, Muzaffarpur, says that "limiting home deliveries to just 2% in Muzaffarpur is a prime example of public participation and systemic commitment". He commended the dedication of ASHA workers, ANMs, CHOs, and local panchayat representatives in transforming age-old mindsets.

The experience of Neelam Devi of Bagha Khal illustrates this transformation. During her first childbirth at home, she faced severe bleeding while the midwife insisted everything was fine. For her second child, she chose a government hospital, where she received security and care that could never have been provided at home. Villages once bound by tradition are now embracing safe motherhood through institutional delivery.

The Muzaffarpur model inspired other districts. In Saran, the Basahya and Konde panchayats reduced home deliveries from 45% to near zero. In Kishanganj's Bahadurganj, Dighalban, Tedagachaj, Potlia, Kochadhaman, and Thakurganj blocks, 95-100% of deliveries now occur in hospitals, proving that geography need not be a barrier when administration, panchayats, and health systems work together.

Dr Indira Prasad, additional professor and gynaecologist, AIIMS, says, "The most effective way to reduce maternal and neonatal mortality is through safe institutional delivery. But it will be sustainable only if women in hospitals get respectable and quality services and availability of all-weather transport in remote areas."

Bihar's 80 home-delivery-free panchayats offer hope in a state where maternal mortality remains higher than the national average. Where home delivery was once tradition, institutional delivery now has social acceptance. Decades-old beliefs change when communities, leaders, and health systems unite.

The views expressed are personal

The Bhakti movement, beyond our textbooks

The much-debated National Education Policy (2020) seeks to root education in the Indian ethos and civilisational heritage. This is welcome. But the real challenge lies not only in intention but also in execution. A good example is whether and how we have attempted to include the globally unparalleled Bhakti movement in our educational curriculum.

How many of us can imagine a lady, as far back as the 12th century, who, covered only by her tresses, wandered nude to Kalyan in present-day Karnataka, to have philosophical dialogue with the great Lingayit seer, Basavanna? Her name was Mahadevi Akka. This conversation took place at a place called the Anubhava Mantapa or 'the hall of spiritual experience', where men and women from all social backgrounds could come to openly discuss spiritual questions or matters of public importance.

Basavanna, along with Allama Prabhu, founded the powerful social reform movement of that time, the Virashaya Movement. Through intensely lyrical and devotional hymns, the Lingayits sought personal communion with Shiva, and rallied against caste customs, superstitions, image worship, animal sacrifices and the caste system. Mahadevi, a wandering mendicant, considered Shiva to be her beloved. Following her dialogue with Basavanna, this wild-looking, completely unconventional woman was honourably admitted to the Lingayit order.

In Maharashtra, the iconic Namadeva (1270-1350 CE), a great devotee of Vitthoba (a form of Vishnu), powerfully argued through his devotional hymns against social hierarchies and ritualistic purity. In fact, his inner circle included a barber, a gardener, a potter, a woman (Janabai, the mad), and even Chokha, an 'untouchable'. These are glimpses from the remarkable Bhakti movement — a powerful reform movement, pan-Indian in scope and lasting for over six centuries in the languages of the masses, and the source of some of our most evocative literature and poetry. Few realise that it also played an important role in Hinduism surviving the proselytisation and plunder of the Turkic invasion. A rainbow-coloured butterfly of this nature, shunning the priestly caste and formal rituals, while combining devotional fervour, direct communion, social irreverence, and the support of the masses, could hardly be killed by the conqueror's sword. Indeed, later, even tenets of Islam, through Sufism, became part of this great crusade.

But is any of this taught in our schools and universities? Students may have studied individual figures — Kabir, Guru Nanak, Tulsi Das, Surdas — but have been taught that all of them were part of an integrated and landmark upsurge to reform, reinterpret, and revive the evolution of Indian thought? The *dramatis personae* of this reawakening spread from the

The *dramatis personae* of the reawakening is an amazing galaxy of literary and spiritual giants.

11th to the 18th century is an amazing galaxy of literary and spiritual giants — the Nayanars and Tamil saints, Jayadeva, Vidyapati, Chandidasa, Bihari, Chaitanya, Amir Khusrau, Rahim, Vallabhacharya, Mirabai, Anand, Tukaram, Lal Daga, Nanmaya, Karakali, Anantpur, Narayana, Mehta, and many more — all of them writing in their local languages, thereby seeping deep into the consciousness of Indians. It is only when we understand that the Bhakti movement is perhaps the world's longest and most vibrant reform movements, inspired by religion and yet protesting its sterile rituals and oppressive hierarchies, can one understand the true meaning and context of what, for instance, Kabir (1440-1518 CE) wrote: "It is but folly to ask what the caste of a saint may be."

The barber has sought God, the washerwoman and the carpenter. Even Radika was a saint after God. The Rishi Swapacha was a tanner by caste. Hindus and Muslims alike have achieved that End. Where remains no mark of distinction.

Similarly, Guru Nanak's (1469-1539 CE) claim on call was to be a universal spiritual appeal. Sikhism, like Vedanta, emphasised the non-duality of divinity — *ek onkar se sab jag upai* (From one luminous light, the entire universe arose). Through this one statement, it pole-vaulted above conventional religious orthodoxies. The Guru Granth Sahib contains the hymns of not only the Sikh Gurus, but also mentions Hindu deities and the teachings of 13 Hindu Bhakti-movement saints, as also Sheikh Farid and Kabir. The *langars* in gurudwaras have never made any distinctions based on caste. Amnesia about the past is unforgivable for great civilisations such as India's. In overcoming it, our educational system can be an important instrument, but only if it is impartially and knowledgeably reconfigured.

Pavan K Varma is an author, diplomat, and former Rajya Sabha MP. The views expressed are personal

{ SUNDAY LETTERS }

Solidarity with women

This is with reference to "Women seldom receive the solidarity they deserve" (column) extended" by Namita Bhandare (August 2). Women are always at the forefront in mass protests, but their voices go unheard when it comes to their rights. They face atrocities and oppression, which needs urgent addressing.

Abhilasha Gupta

The power of constitutional conventions

This is with reference to "The British ceremonies of PMs demitting office" by Karan Thapar (August 2). Such swift and seamless transfer of power reflects respect for constitutional conventions. Prolonged political transitions create unnecessary spectacle. India can draw inspiration from such conventions.

Sanjay Chopra

II. Such ceremonies in a democracy might appear odd, but, usually, a profound principle underlies these protocols. The UK's protocol on PMs' exit has immense signalling value to British politics, on grace in defeat.

Divya Mallick

Write to us at: letters@hindustantimes.com

HT wknd

A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY

Sharmila Dhankar

Heavy mettle

She has won India's first-ever gold medal in para-athletics at the Commonwealth Games. Dhankar is 39 years old, and has only been a sportsperson for six years. Before that, she was a battered wife and mother. Before that, a child with polio, mocked by the people around her. A second marriage brought love into her life, and purpose. 'I don't bother too much about history. I'd rather create some of my own,' she says

Shantanu Srivastava
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What are you aiming for, she was asked, at a Delhi press meet, two days before the Indian contingent left for the Commonwealth Games (CWG) in Glasgow.

"Gold," said Sharmila Dhankar, 39. "There's no other medal I want. Gold is what I'll go for."

No one paid much attention. There were stars of the para-athlete world here. Dhankar was an unknown entity.

I will now admit I was in the crowd that day and found the assertion a bit preposterous.

Dhankar had yet to win a major international medal. Her six-year career involved fourth-place finishes at the CWG in Birmingham (2022) and at the Asian Para Games in Hangzhou (2023), and a fifth-place result at the World Para Athletics Championships in New Delhi (2025).

"I don't bother too much about history," she had said, when reminded of this. "I'd rather create some of my own." "That wasn't just what she said; it's what she did."

On July 27, Dhankar hurled a 3kg iron ball 9.81m to earn India's first-ever gold in para-athletics at a CWG. (She is also the first Indian woman to ever win a para-athletics medal at a CWG).

"I told you I'd come back with gold, and here I am," she beamed, thrusting her medal towards the camera later that day.

There's a certain joie de vivre about Dhankar. She speaks with a smile that never leaves her face.

"I found joy so late in life that I can't afford to lose my smile," she says. "It's been a long and painful journey."

The second of four siblings, Dhankar was born to an impoverished farmer and a visually impaired homemaker in Haryana's Mahendragarh district.

She contracted polio at the age of two, and grew up isolated from the friendships and

hours of play that can ease a harsh childhood. It was often worse than isolation.

In school and at home, at social gatherings and over quiet meals, she became the butt of jokes.

"I don't blame these people entirely," she says. "That was how things were for people with disabilities where I grew up, and so they didn't know any better. But it hurt. Obviously it hurt."

She was married at 19, and things got worse. The domestic abuse she faced intensified after the birth of her two daughters, "and there were times I thought of ending it all," she says. "I hated my life. There was no purpose, just struggle, and nothing to look forward to. I lived in constant fear, and I didn't have the courage to speak out."

Seven years in, as the abuse escalated, she left and returned home.

Two years later she met a man of limited means, a mechanic named Ajit Singh, and a new family formed. He treated her and her daughters with love. "He motivated me to do something with my life," Dhankar says.

Encouraged by him, she enrolled at the Rao Tularam Stadium near their home in Rewari, in 2020. "Most athletes retire at 34 and here I was, looking for a fresh start," she says, grinning.

Blessed with natural upper-body strength, Dhankar took to the shot put with ease. She trained under Tek Chand, who won a shot put bronze at the 2018 Asian Para Games.

"It was a little awkward to train with girls less than half my age, but it was soon okay. I got a lot of support from my coach and other trainees," she says.

A year into her "second life," Dhankar won at the National Championship, setting a national record of 7.40m.

She qualified for the 2022 Birmingham CWG, where she set a new national record (8.43m). At the 2025 World Para Athletics Championships in New Delhi, she set another (10.03m).

By this point, a dream was taking shape, but dreams take money.

In 2023, Singh sold a house in Sonapat for Rs 10 lakh. Dhankar's mother Santosh Dhankar sold land for Rs 24 lakh.



WATCH Sharmila Dhankar discuss her gold, moments after winning it



This sport gave me a purpose, a second birth. I want to say to women facing domestic abuse: Don't be scared. Take your shot and your life might just change completely.

"They wanted me to excel at the 2025 Worlds, but a fifth-place finish is all I could manage. I was not happy with the results. Looking at sacrifices my family was making, I felt an overpowering sense of guilt," Dhankar says. "It wasn't easy to eat what I needed while the family didn't. It is not easy to raise an athlete, without a lot of resources. It was hard. My family had to go without. That's why my only target this time was gold."

Back home with the promised gold, Dhankar has a new dream: She wants to help buy back the land they sold.

She has another dream too, one that may

or may not come true.

She wants to compete at a CWG alongside her daughters: 15-year-old Anuj, who has taken up the javelin, and 13-year-old Laxmi, training as a long-jumper.

The mother and daughters now train together at Rao Tularam Stadium. In the immediate future, the gold-medallist has her sights set on the Asian Para Games in Japan in October and the LA Paralympics in 2028.

"This sport gave me a purpose, a second birth," Dhankar says. "I want to say to women facing domestic abuse: Don't be scared. Take your shot, and your life might just change completely."

1 It was Sharmila Dhankar's second husband, Ajit Singh, who "motivated me to do something with my life," she says. She enrolled at the Rao Tularam Stadium near their home in Rewari in 2020 and, blessed with natural upper-body strength, took to the shot put with ease.

2 She trained under Tek Chand, who won shot put bronze at the 2018 Asian Para Games. "It was a little awkward at first to train with girls less than half my age, but it was soon okay. I got a lot of support from my coach and other trainees," she says.

3 Dhankar's dream now is to help buy back the land her husband and her mother sold to fund her training. She also dreams of competing at a CWG alongside her daughters: 15-year-old Anuj, who has taken up the javelin, and 13-year-old Laxmi, who is training as a long-jumper.

inside



LIFESTYLE

The It guy

What makes Stephen King the master of horror isn't just the monsters. It's that he is writing about our deepest fears: grief, mortality, the loss of those we love. He's asking the difficult questions: What truly frightens us? How far will we go? What do we owe the people we love, when a monster turns up at the door? In this special, K Narayanan interviews Caroline Bicks, a professor of literature who spent a year shadowing the author for her new book on him, *Monsters in the Archives*

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CULTURE

Turning pointe

A problematic ballet set in India has been reimagined by Indian and Dutch researchers, and the results are resonant, beautiful and far more authentic

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URBAN

Step write in

A museum of children's notebooks in Milan offers details of everyday life going back centuries – as well as notes on what children really want, the battles they fight, and ways in which they wish their world was different

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wknd lifestyle

The 11
guy

What makes Stephen King the master of horror isn't just the monsters. It's that he's writing about our deepest fears: grief, mortality, the loss of those we love. He is asking the difficult questions: What truly frightens us? How far will we go? What do we owe the people we love, when a monster turns up at the door? In this special, K Narayanan interviews Caroline Bicks, a professor of literature who spent a year shadowing the author, for her new book on him, *Monsters in the Archives*

K Narayanan
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Stephen King has been writing for a long time. His first story, *I Was a Teenage Grave Robber*, was published 61 years ago, in 1965. His first novel, the bestselling *Carrie*, was released in 1974. He was 26 years old. In his memoir, *On Writing* (2000), he described his routine as 2,000 words a day, every day. King is now 78. He has written 66 novels/novellas, over 200 short stories, and five non-fiction works (dealing largely with elements of horror).

Stacked on top of each other, they'd reach the height of a young giraffe, or the hoop on a basketball court. King often downplays his significance and influence, calling himself, among other things, "America's schlockmeister" (essentially, the literary equivalent of a burger and fries). But his books retain their appeal and longevity, not just because of the scary monsters they contain, but because of the things those monsters threaten.

That's the idea that sits at the heart of *Monsters in the Archives: My Year of Fear* with Stephen King, the new book by University of Maine's Caroline Bicks (naturally, the Stephen E. King Chair in literature there). Bicks, 39, spent a year with unprecedented access to King's manuscript archives.

She went looking for craft and found plenty. She also found grief.

Studying early drafts of his novels from the '70s and '80s (*Carrie*, *The Shining*, *Salem's Lot*, *Night Shift*, and *Pet Sematary*), she watched King's fiction return again and again to a single wound: the loss of a mother. King lost his mother, Nellie Ruth King, to cancer when he was 25; she was 60. It's a motif she says she never set out to find; it simply emerged, in one draft and then the next, until it became impossible to ignore.

This pattern helps explain why the horror that endures from King isn't the visible kind. It's the fear that someone you love will be taken from you, and that nothing — not faith, willpower or a pet cemetery built on cursed ground — can bring them all the way back.

What emerges, from the archive and from the screen, is a writer less interested in what frightens us than in what we can't stop loving, and what such love can cost. Fifty-two years after *Carrie*, King's most durable trick isn't the monstrous hotel or the killer car. It's the ordinary, unbearable fact that everyone we love is eventually lost to us.

Excerpts from an interview with Bicks, on her year with Stephen King.

How did this all come about?

I came to the University of Maine about nine years ago as a Shakespeare scholar, not a horror scholar. The chair was endowed in Stephen King's name, but that was because he was our most famous alumnus.

This book developed four years into the job, when he called me and I started to get to know him. I'd always been a King fan. I was really intrigued by the opportunity to go into his archives. We had never let anyone in there for extended amounts of time before.

I thought: This is what I love to do — study language and study how great works get written. His books have stayed with me 40 years after I read them. I wanted to understand why. How did he do it?

We often forget that he wrote novels before *Carrie*. They just weren't published until much later. He was only 18 when he wrote *The Long Walk*, (1979; about a dystopian alternative US ruled by a totalitarian regime).

When I read *The Long Walk* this year, I noticed he was quoting Andrew Marvell, the 17th-century poet. And it struck me that he's always been thinking about poetry, and about sound... He knows exactly how to take a simple sound like "oh" and stretch it into something much more unsettling.

We actually had a wonderful exchange a while ago about *Salem's Lot* (1975; a man returns to his hometown to discover its residents are turning into vampires).

He told me he was reading a great deal of James Dickey's poetry when he wrote it, and it influenced its beautifully lyrical chapters... where the town becomes almost a living presence, with its own secrets. So even back then, he was thinking about poetic language and poetic sound.

When did you first realise that King wasn't simply a pulp writer?

I'd say it probably happened when I read *The Body* (1982), and later watched the film adaptation. Stand by Me (1986; four boys go looking for a teenager who has gone missing and is presumed dead).

That's such a deeply human story. It's really about friendship. There's that famous line: "I never had any friends older on like the ones I had when I was twelve." I think that's probably the work that made me appreciate another side of his writing.

Then, while researching this book, I reread *Night Shift* (1978; King's first short-story collection). I'd forgotten it ends with *The Woman in the Room* (about a man who decides to euthanise his terminally ill mother). That was really the moment when everything clicked for me. King wasn't simply writing about monsters. He was writing about our deepest fears: grief, mortality, and losing the people we love. Those are the things that truly frighten us.

So much of horror is about death. And yet, in *Pet Sematary*, the metaphor of *Oz* the Great and Terrible suggests death is a fake, like the man behind the curtain...

That's interesting because in our final conversation, we ended up talking about death. Stephen said something like, "What if that's all there is? What if you die, and then there's simply... nothing?" We imagine death to be this enormous, terrifying, all-powerful force. But what if, in the end, it is simply nothing? No great revelation. No grand judgment. Just an ending. That's an extraordinarily frightening idea... We've built it into something immense and overwhelming, but perhaps it is far more ordinary.

When reading *The Shining*, the references to *Hamlet* stand out. In *Carrie*, King explicitly invokes *Macbeth*. Has the influence ever worked in the opposite direction? Do you ever read Shakespeare and think of something King wrote?

Absolutely. Shakespeare was one of the original horror writers. Think of *Titus Andronicus*, which was also enormously popular in its own time. Audiences have always loved blood, violence and terror in stories that push emotional boundaries. I feel fortunate that I can teach courses where I bring Shakespeare and Stephen King together. Even before I met Stephen, when I first arrived at the University of Maine, I taught a course called *Horror and Humanity*. We read *Carrie* (1974; about a tormented friendless teen who discovers she has special powers) alongside *Macbeth* because I wanted students to think about the questions both works are asking. What are the limits of humanity? How does fear turn someone into a monster?

Macbeth's terror begins almost as soon as the witches tell him he will be king. He is already imagining murdering Duncan. I found myself thinking about *Carrie* in much the same way. At what point does she begin to detach from her humanity? What makes a person capable of terrible violence?

One of the fascinating things about studying the manuscripts was watching Stephen gradually move away from the more graphic comic-book horror. The earliest draft portrays *Carrie* almost as an alien. She sprouts horns. She revels in her power. You really

can't feel sorry for her. But as he keeps rewriting, you can actually watch him developing empathy for her.

What other evolutions did you spot in the archives?

Well, when he was drafting *Carrie* and *Salem's Lot*, he was also writing all these short stories that he was trying to sell to men's magazines. He and (his wife, the writer) Tabitha King desperately needed money. So those early drafts naturally have more of that short, sharp, visceral horror; stories such as *Children of the Corn* (first published in 1977 in *Penthouse*) and *Graveyard Shift* (1970; *Cavalier* magazine).

As he gradually moved away from having to write simply to pay the bills, I think he gave himself permission to lean into longer, more psychological narratives. But I don't think he had to learn how to do that. *The Long Walk* proves that he already knew.

Did you notice any other changes, in those early years?

Well, when Stephen is writing many of the *Night Shift* stories, he isn't a parent yet. By the time he's writing *Carrie*, his children are still very young. Then he writes *The Shining* (1977; a man in a haunted hotel turns into a monster who threatens his family), which grows out of a nightmare he had about a firehouse chasing his son in a hotel corridor. Then comes *Pet Sematary* (1983), written while the family was renting a house beside a dangerous road, where his other son nearly ran into traffic. Did becoming a father of three change the fears that animated his fiction? I think that's inevitable. Parenthood changes your relationship with fear.

Match the stills above to the plots at right. Can you spot: *Salem's Lot*, 1972, Apt Pupil, Gerald's Game, *Carrie*, *The Night Flier*, *Dolan's Cadillac*, *The Shining*, and *Pet Sematary*. GETTY IMAGES

{ INTENSIVE SCARE UNIT } THE WATCH LIST

Scream therapy: A top 10 of rare King adaptations

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The 10 lesser-known Stephen King adaptations here are films that rarely make the "best-of" lists, but circle the same wounds from different angles. These are tales of loss, guilt, the catastrophe of consequence. The discovery that corruption and delusion can live quietly inside an ordinary person. And the question of what a person owes the people they love, when a monster turns up at the door.

The Night Flier

Richard Dees, a ruthless reporter for a sensationalist tabloid, pursues a suspected serial killer named Dwight Renfield aka the Night Flier (1997), who appears to travel between small airports in a black aircraft.

As Dees follows the trail of increasingly gruesome murders, he discovers the killer may be a vampire. Miguel Ferrer revels in the role of a seedy, ambitious reporter forced to confront something beyond rational explanation. Critically savaged when it came out, it has since acquired a cult following.

Dolan's Cadillac

Tom Robinson (Wes Bentley) lives a quiet life until his wife witnesses an execution ordered by crime boss Jimmy Dolan (Christian Slater). When the gangster has her murdered, Robinson becomes consumed by grief and the idea of revenge. He devises an elaborate plan that takes years to execute, centred on Dolan's Cadillac (2009).

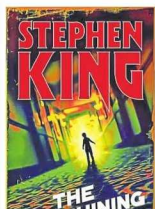
More crime-thriller than horror, the film explores obsession, perseverance, and the psychological cost of vengeance. Watch it if you appreciate carefully constructed revenge stories over explosive action.

Apt Pupil

Todd Bowden, an intelligent but disturbed high-school student, discovers that an elderly neighbour is really a Nazi war criminal. Rather than expose him, Bowden blackmails the old man into recounting his wartime atrocities. Their relationship gradually corrupts them both.

Jan McKellen is chilling as the former SS officer, as Apt Pupil (1998) examines how quietly evil can seduce. This is one of King's darkest non-supernatural stories.





Shining star: The life and times of Stephen King

Stephen King, 78, was born in Portland, Maine, to a travelling salesman of vacuum cleaners named Donald Edwin King and Nellie Ruth King. His father left the family when King was two. Nellie Ruth worked multiple jobs, including as a caregiver, to support herself and her two sons, Stephen and his elder brother David.

King began writing when he was about six, copying out stories at first from comic books. It was his mother who suggested he write tales of his own. In his memoir *On Writing* (2000), he recalls "an immense feeling of possibility at the idea, as if I had been ushered into a vast building filled with closed doors and had been given the key to open any I liked".

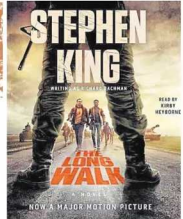
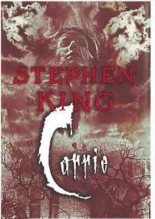
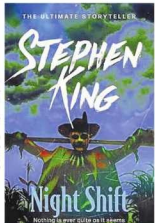
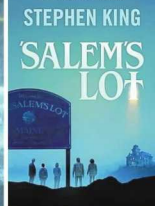
In 1966, he secured a scholarship to study English at University of Maine, which is where he met his wife, future author Tabitha Sprue. A year later, he began selling stories to magazines. When he graduated in 1970, he was unable to find a job as a teacher, so he worked for a while at an industrial laundry.

He began teaching English in a high school in Maine in 1971. He and Tabitha Sprue married the same year. Around this time, he also began work on his debut novel, *Carrie*.

Amid growing fame, the 1980s saw him struggle with addiction. In his memoir, he writes of barely remembering writing *Cujo* (1981) about a dog who contracts rabies and goes on a killing spree. King has been sober since a family intervention in the late 1980s.

King is today one of the most-adapted living authors of his time, with over 100 films, TV series and miniseries based on works ranging from *Carrie*, *The Shining*, *Pet Sematary* and *It* to the lesser-known *Mr. Mercedes*, *Christine*, and *Doctor Sleep*.

He and his wife live largely in Maine. They have three children, Naomi, Joe and Owen; and four grandchildren.



Secret Window

Mort Rainey, a writer recovering from a painful divorce, retreats to an isolated cabin hoping for solitude, only to have a stranger accuse him of plagiarism. Amid a series of increasingly disturbing events, Rainey's grip on reality begins to loosen. In *Secret Window* (2004), Johnny Depp delivers a subdued performance that keeps the audience wondering what is real, until the story's unsettling end.

1922

Set on a Nebraska farm, the story follows Wilfred James, who persuades his teenage son to help murder his wife after she decides to revive their inherited land. Guilt then manifests as hallucinations, supernatural suggestions and relentless misfortune. Thomas Jane is exceptional in this rural Gothic 2017 film about the slow, inevitable consequences of unforgivable choices.

Gerald's Game

Jessie Burlingame accompanies her husband Gerald to a secluded lake house in an attempt to revive their marriage. During a role-playing game, he handcuffs her to the bed, before suddenly dying of a heart attack. Trapped and alone, Burlingame confronts traumatic childhood memories, while trying to find ways to survive. Mike Flanagan transforms King's intensely internal novel into a gripping psychological thriller. Carla Gugino's remarkable performance carries the 2017 film about resilience, trauma and the possibility of reclaiming one's life from the past.



Doctor Sleep

Years after surviving the *Overlook Hotel*, a now-grown Danny Torrance (Ewan McGregor) struggles with alcoholism and lingering trauma while trying to suppress his psychic abilities (known as "the shining"). Then he encounters Abra, a gifted young woman pursued by a cult that feeds on children with supernatural powers. Forced to embrace the abilities he has long rejected, Torrance confronts external monsters and his own past. Mike Flanagan balances supernatural horror with emotional storytelling in *Doctor Sleep* (2019), while acknowledging Stanley Kubrick's iconic film.

The Dead Zone

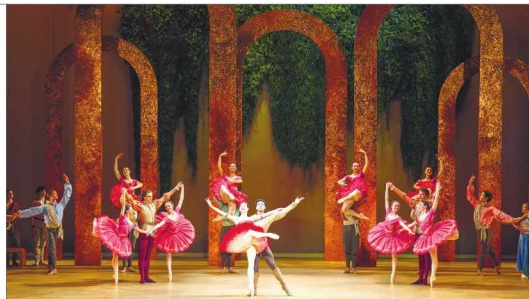
Schoolteacher Johnny Smith wakes after a five-year coma to discover he now has psychic abilities that let him see people's pasts and possible futures. He initially uses his gift to help people, but eventually foresees that

King's books lend themselves to ongoing conversations in cinema. Above left, Jack Nicholson in the 1980 film *The Shining*. Above right, Ewan McGregor in his sequel, *Doctor Sleep* (2019).

As a devastating blizzard isolates the small island of Little Tall, a stranger named André Linoge start to expose the townspeople's deepest secrets. Possessed of seemingly supernatural powers, Linoge demands the community surrender "what I want", forcing them into an impossible moral choice that pits collective survival against individual conscience. Written directly for television by King, the 1999 miniseries' unforgettable villain and haunting conclusion have made it a favourite of King fans.

Riding the Bullet

College student Alan Parker decides to hitchhike home after learning that his mother has suffered a stroke. During the journey, one driver's unsettling behaviour begins to suggest that he may not be among the living. Blending supernatural encounters with reflections on grief, death and the difficult transition into adulthood, *Riding the Bullet* (2004) unfolds as an unusually contemplative dreamlike meditation on mortality.



culture

Turning pointe

A problematic ballet set in India has been reimagined by Indian and Dutch researchers, and the results are resonant, beautiful and authentic

Sukanya Datta

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The original La Bayadere (The Temple Dancer) featured sadhus in blackface, villainous stereotypes—but spectacular music and choreography. The revised tale features Dutch officials, mixed-race dancers and authentic backdrops. (Below) Anna Tsygankov as the lead character Nikiya. IMAGES COURTESY ALINKA KATIRA

Few classical ballets carry as much beauty, and baggage, as *La Bayadere* (The Temple Dancer). For nearly 150 years, this classic created by French choreographer Marius Petipa has told the story of a temple dancer and a warrior who fall in love in India. This is, however, an India of colonial stereotype: half-naked sadhus represented by Whites in blackface dance around fires; scheming priests and kings abound; and the elaborate sets are a mishmash of indistinguishable arched and domed architecture.

The choreography is exquisite, though. As is the music, and dramatic tension. How does one contend with a work from 1877 that is both essential and problematic?

This year, the Dutch National Ballet (DNB) in Amsterdam decided to find a way. It chose neither to preserve the fantasy nor ignore the ballet. Instead, it debuted a reimagined version earlier this year. This *La Bayadere* alters the plot, recasts some of the characters, and situates the tale in real locations in Dutch colonial India.

In doing so, it subtly nudges its largely European audiences to engage with their own problematic past.

The ballet is co-directed by Dutch-Indian dancer, choreographer and anthropologist Kalpana Raghuraman and Australian-Indian dancer, choreographer and researcher Priya Srinivasan, alongside DNB director Ted Branden and associate artistic director Rachel Beaujean. It is now set in 17th-century Sadras, the Dutch East India Company's fortified settlement in coastal Tamil Nadu.

While preserving much of Petipa's choreography, it tips its hat to marginalised Indian musicians and dancers, with a montage of stills and short clips paying tribute and finally entering them into the historical record. Chennai-based musician and visual artist Tenna, co-founder of the band Castle Collective, orchestrated this element, curating images of Dalit, Bahujan and Adivasi performers.

Step by step

"We wanted to turn the colonial mirror the other way, and imagine what *La Bayadere* could have looked like if it was created with all the information and awareness available today," says Srinivasan.

The original story follows Solor, a warrior, and Nikiya, a temple dancer, whose love is doomed from the start. To begin with, a

character named High Brahmin, a priest, is in love with her too. Then, the raja of Golkonda commands Solor to marry his daughter Gamzatti, and he decides to obey.

As preparations for the wedding begin, the High Brahmin tells the king about Nikiya and Solor's ongoing relationship. Gamzatti tries to beg, bribe and bully the dancer into ending it.

Nikiya, meanwhile, is commissioned to perform at the celebrations, where she is killed by a venomous snake planted by Gamzatti. Solor, consumed by grief, dreams of reuniting with her in the after-life. Then, as Solor and Gamzatti are about to be married, divine forces set the kingdom ablaze. When DNB reached out, Raghuraman says, "they asked if I thought the ballet should be cancelled or could be reimagined in some way. I roped in Priya, and we started discussing a decolonised approach, based on historical evidence."

Backstage passes

Research led Srinivasan to Fort Sadras, where she found the graves of Dutch colonial officers and soldiers. "This allowed us to use actual historical figures as sources of inspiration," she says.

In the reimagined ballet, Solor is a captain in the Dutch army; the high priest has been replaced by a corrupt Dutch merchant. The raja is a half-Japanese-half-Dutch governor.

Because DNB has a diverse cast, and 17th-century South India was so cosmopolitan, different races and nationalities can be represented. Nikiya, for instance, is now a mixed-race dancer (abandoned as a child and given to the temple to raise).

In place of the original opening sequence, of sadhus in blackface dancing around a fire, it opens with the tribute to marginalised classical and folk artists such as Karagam dancers S Thangaila, S Poozhivi and Priyadarshini, a Bharatanatyam dancer Mukesh Aman, and yash player Tharun Sekar. Some are shown performing; others simply stare into the audience. "S Thangaila looking at the audience is meant to be a haunting moment," Tenna says. "Like the ghost of the dancers and musicians who never got to write their names into history."

One of the issues they couldn't fix, Raghuraman says, was the death of Nikiya. "Why do women always have to die? We debated this a lot. We unfortunately couldn't change it. But we have reframed it in a way where her death is a foreshadowing of the larger destruction." This kind of project still marks a new direction, Raghuraman adds. "It remains incredibly difficult to represent Indian dance forms and dancers on the international stage without cliché or exoticisation rearing their heads. But every small thing that we changed opens up new possibilities for future practitioners and projects."

{ THE SPORTING LIFE }

Rudraneil Sengupta

In the throws of victory

The seed Neeraj Chopra planted in 2021 is bearing fruit across the subcontinent. Could cricket be a small part of the reason too?

That hot, humid night in Tokyo, standing in an eerily empty Olympic stadium, did Neeraj Chopra think of the ripples his historic gold might cause?

At the time, in 2021, Chopra was a freak occurrence: no one had seen a javelin thrower from India, or in fact from anywhere in South Asia, make it to an Olympic final, let alone win the thing.

By the next edition of the Games, Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem, who finished fifth in Tokyo, was on the podium, becoming the first individual Olympic gold medalist from his country at Paris 2024. His gold-medal throw set a new Olympic record, of 92.97 metres. He and Chopra stood side by side in Paris, in a 1-2 finish for Asia.

South Asia is now the epicentre for javelin throw. On June 4 this year, in Rome, former

Javelin throwers Ramesh Pathirage of Sri Lanka, and India's Annu Rani and Neeraj Chopra. IMAGES: PFL, GETTY, AN



Sri Lankan fast-bowler Ramesh Pathirage hurled the javelin 92.62 metres to win gold at the Diamond League Golden Gala, recording the second-best throw in Asian history (behind Nadeem's Olympic one).

The javelin final at the Commonwealth Games on August 1 finished with Pathirage, 23, winning gold and Chopra, now 26, winning silver. Third place went to a rising star in Indian javelin-throw, 24-year-old Yashvir Singh. The 12-man final featured three Indians, a Sri Lankan and a Pakistani.

Chopra has set quite a ball rolling. In recent years, India alone has seen Kishore Jena, DP Manu and Sachin Yadav make the world championships final, Chopra and Jena pull off a gold-silver finish at the Asian Games in 2023, and Annu Rani won the women's gold at the same event.

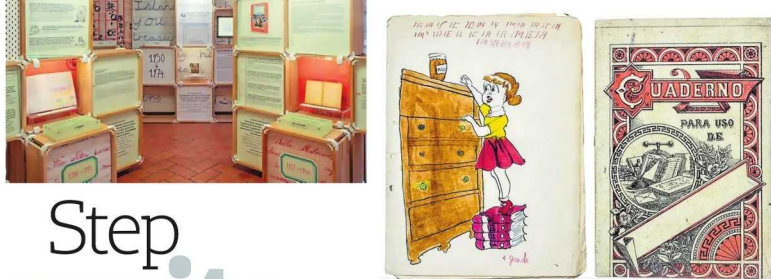
Before Chopra, there was barely any representation from India, Pakistan or Sri Lanka in this javelin throw. So their disciplines, his gold opened a floodgate, allowing in the element of belief: if he can do it, maybe I can too. Amid the growing ambition, world-class training centres opened, better coaches were drawn to them, and a shift in priorities led to more government funding too.

We have come to realise that cricket, the one sport that rules India, Pakistan and Sri Lanka, works on the same biomechanics as the javelin throw. So their disciplines, his gold opened a floodgate, allowing in the element of belief: if he can do it, maybe I can too. Amid the growing ambition, world-class training centres opened, better coaches were drawn to them, and a shift in priorities led to more government funding too.

Chopra and a clutch of Indians, as well as Pathirage and Nadeem, will all go head-to-head at the Asian Games in 2026, in what promises to be another South Asian fireworks show, in this ancient war game-turned-sport.

(Email rudraneil@gmail.com. The views expressed are personal)

wknd urban



Step write in

A museum of children's notebooks in Milan offers details of everyday life going back centuries – as well as notes on what children want, the battles they fight, and ways in which they wish their world was different

Gowri S

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“Yesterday was a bad day...” a 12-year-old from Lombardy, Italy writes, during World War I. “Today the sun barely shines and although it’s just one o’clock there have already been three alarms. I cannot understand how I’m supposed to live this way.”

In 1824, in France, a middle-school girl writes to her mother, asking to be allowed to stay in school. “Your silence began to cause me worry... it is very unlike you to let pass such a long time without writing,” she writes, in careful, cursive lines. “I beg you to give me another six more months... I beg you, Dear Mama.”

In Jaipur, the diary of a child of about 12 goes from descriptions of daily life to anguish over a fire at an oil depot. Rescue operation cannot even begin for the first 48 hours, she writes. As high as a kite and as low as a kite, “The fire could be easily seen from my classroom,” she notes. “Nothing is in order.”

We don’t think of children as keepers of history, but as they too navigate the world and attempt to make sense of it, there is emotion, pathos and immense detail in the records they keep; and a view from a unique perspective.

An entire parallel history of this kind now sits in a 650-sq-ft museum of children’s notebooks in Milan. There are 2,500 documents preserved here. Most are notebooks, diaries, letters and journals, sourced via antique dealers and collectors or sent in by families.

They contain the impressions of children from over 35 countries, written in more than 18 languages. (All names are withheld, to protect identities. Works are translated into Italian and English by museum volunteers.)

The oldest artefact is a penmanship exercise book from Shropshire, England, dated 1773. The most recent additions are exercise books from Ghana, dated 2012.

The Museum of Children’s Notebooks began in 2004, when journalist and photographer Thomas Pololi, then 22, invited peo-

ple from across Italy to send in their old school essays. These tended to be personal tales on a child’s world, their most recent holiday or routine events from their lives.

As the collection expanded, support and funding grew. In 2014, Pololi founded the non-profit organisation Quaderni Aperti or Open Exercise Books, which now runs the physical museum.

“I believe the universal voice of children is one of humanity’s most important heritage assets, not only for understanding childhood, but for understanding humanity itself,” says Pololi, 44. “We have found this is true beyond national borders and historical periods.”

He points to the diary from Jaipur. As the tragedy disrupts her life (the 2009 fire at an Indian Oil Corporation terminal blazed for 11 days and claimed 12 lives), “it becomes an example of how history on the grand scale intersects with the microhistories of ordinary people, including children.”

Line drawings

Pololi believes the diaries hold something more: clues to ways in which we can make the world better. Leafing through the notebooks is a reminder of what humanity needs more, and less of.

The first thing children ask for is often freedom. They want spaces where they can play freely with their peers, and they want to be able to reach those spaces independently,” says Pololi (left). Today, that freedom to play is increasingly threatened.

With fewer physical spaces set aside for them, and many more screens available, they seek this freedom and community online. “Sadly, this can be far more harmful and dangerous than a park or public square.”

Also present through the museum’s collection is the tragic ever-presence of war. The institute is currently preparing, in fact, for an exhibition titled War Notebooks, that will explore conflicts of the 20th century through such testimonies by children from

Italy, Japan, China, Germany, the UK and US.

Unsurprisingly, another key area of conflict is the pressure of expectations. Children write of working harder to make parents proud; of adhering to lists of set goals.

It shows, Pololi says, that all too often, what we think of as the kind of discipline that is needed, to help a child become an informed adult, is experienced as a kind of indoctrination, a pressure to be useful, gifted, exceptional – which, by the math alone, the average child simply cannot be.

Send a text

There are scribbles from children as young as four in the museum, “but we generally focus on somewhat longer, more ‘aware’ texts. Those written between the ages of eight and 13 or 14 tend to have both the expressive freshness of childhood and the communicative precision of someone who has already gained real writing competence,” Pololi says.

Only material from people who have reached adulthood are accepted. “This is partly for reasons of privacy and data protection, and partly just practical: without the ‘filtering’ effect that the passage of time provides, we’d likely end up with far more material than we could ever manage,” Pololi says. “Though submissions are always welcome.”

In the library are accounts of an Australian child who dreamed of travelling to the Moon in the 1950s; the adventures of a group of Finnish Girl Scouts who recorded their outings in a shared diary during the same period; writings by a French girl who enthusiastically described a flight on a Boeing aircraft in the 1970s.

Sometimes, nothing serves as a record of history too.

A tiny pocket diary belonging to a child from Connecticut in the late-1800s notes the repetitive course of his life in rural America. “It is cloudy and looks like snow... It is still very cold. I did not go to school today.”

(To share a text, go to childrensnotebooks.org)



READ How of fame: Could your home hold an artefact of national importance?

(Clockwise from top) An inside view of the museum; a 1950s exercise book from Spain; another on grammar and religion from 1895; and a schoolgirl’s notebook from 1977 Beijing. MUSEUM OF CHILDREN’S NOTEBOOKS VIA INSTAGRAM

[WITH LOVE]

Simran Mangharam

Match point

Some of the greatest love stories in the world, including a number of real-world ones, start the same way: strangers meet or lock eyes across a room and sparks fly. Is the scepticism of our times killing the chance of such frisson?

The beauty of romance is that a spark can catch anywhere, with anybody. Sometimes all it takes is a glance, and two strangers recognise in each other something they have been looking for. A flash of interest, intrigue, humour, or something else intriguing.

A smile may follow, and a conversation, or more.

Across cultures, this is how it has worked. I’d like to talk today about ephemeral romantic connection. And how the scepticism of our times could be endangering it.

This kind of frisson is so universal and ancient that our stories are full of it. Urdu poems, Latin verse, Shakespearean plays and Bollywood films. The heartbeating story of The Bridges of Madison County (1992) begins in a way (a man stops to ask for directions to a local bridge, and a lonely wife and mother offers to take him there).

One of my favourite such tales is the plot of Before Sunrise (1995), a romantic drama directed and co-written by Richard Linklater. An American tourist named Jesse (Ethan Hawke) and a French university student, Celine (Julie Delpy), meet on a train and decide to disembark in Vienna to spend the night together, with the knowledge that they will part at dawn.

Such romances may be short-lived, or may blossom into entire lives spent together.

I had such an experience at the American Embassy, decades ago. Standing in line to enter, I locked eyes with a handsome young man. After about half an hour of stolen glances,



How many of us would smile at a stranger today, exchange names, or allow for the idea that they may not be a threat? (Above) A still from The Bridges of Madison County (1992).

es, we finally entered the embassy together and, as we sat waiting our turn, graduated to nervous smiles. I went in first, and, being a true romantic, waited for him outside.

As he exited, I said, “Hi, how was it?” We walked down the road, chatted, exchanged landline numbers, but never called or met again. Thirty years later, I’m still smiling as I write about that day. It took the edge off my nervousness over the interview process.

What inspired me to write about this now were the recent protests, where a number of young people experienced short-lived romantic connections too. From memes about “uninstalling dating apps because the best place to meet like-minded people is here” to people sharing beds with those they were developing a crush on, this light-hearted approach to love felt so refreshing.

We spend too much of our lives suspicious of each other. The protests, in a way, created a shared space that felt communal and safe. We need more spaces that allow us to feel like this: youth clubs, community centres, third places. Sadly, we don’t have very many.

Instead, we spend our free time gazing into the eyes of strangers who can never really look back at us. And when a person

don’t know smiles at us in the real world, we are programmed to respond with suspicion.

As a dating coach, I find myself discussing this more frequently with clients. We can’t have meet-cutes in the real world, if we refuse to engage. Safely. With caution. But in ways that allow suspicion to wait its turn. Honestly, little harm can come of having a conversation with someone at the grocery store (yes, it’s a good idea to get out there yourself and not rely on an app to bring everything, including love, to your door), a doctor’s waiting room, or in queue for a croissant, restaurant table... or visa.

I would offer one important piece of advice: refrain from behaving like a predator. These are not hunting grounds. Do not stare and scout. Do not make strangers uncomfortable. Smile if it seems someone might be on the verge of smiling. Prepare to be wrong, and retreat immediately and with grace.

There is love and joy out there in the world. Don’t snatch at it. But don’t inoculate yourself against it either.

(Simran Mangharam is a dating and relationship coach and can be reached on simranflow.in. The views expressed are personal)



{ PHOTOBOOK } VINTAGE GOAN HOMES

Down memory lane

Anesha George

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Wander through Goan homes of a certain vintage, and every corner tells a surprising story, says Ulka Chauhan.

In her photobook, The Memory Keepers and Future Seekers, the advertising executive-turned-documentary photographer visits six such bungalows, recording a history that could soon be gone.

Within, she presents through 120 photographs furniture with Hindu iconography carved into it, large salas or halls that seem to echo with the music of saxophones and trumpets, a nonagenarian sitting alone at a rosewood table that once seated 20.

Stories spill out of the book. In one, windows have recently been fitted with grilles, in a quiet reminder of how much has changed. Until a decade ago, in most villages here, front doors were left unlocked.

These bungalows represent a permanence that is rare today, Chauhan says.

“Walls still display rows of ancestral portraits, from a time those alive have no record of.” They also hold signs of key turning points: bullet holes from revolts; changing architecture.

In pre-colonial Goan homes, for instance, the sangan or courtyard was the heart of family life. It was with the arrival of the Portuguese in the 16th century that houses turned outward, with the colourful facades, oyster-shell windows and shaded balconies.

In the different architecture styles preserved, this transition is visible.

Home run

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looking inward herself, she says.

Confined during the pandemic to her family’s nearly-80-year-old two-storey bungalow in suburbs of Mumbai, she found herself thinking about what makes homes endure as heritage.

She was struck at the time by photographer Prabuddha Dasgupta’s photobook Edge of Faith (2009), which looked at Goa’s Catholic community. In 2021, as the world opened up, she began to make frequent trips to the state.

She became intrigued by the grand houses she saw in the villages she visited most often, and started to visit them to talk to their owners. Through conversations over long lunches and dinners, and one 92nd birthday party, Chauhan pieced their stories together.

This grew into a project for an international photo festival in Zurich. Then came the photobook, with six essays by art writer Samira Sheth, one on each of the families featured.

Each of the six tells a dramatic story. In Ranjeev Pele Jesus Fernandes’s 500-year-old family home in Chandor, there is a hidden underground passageway, and bullet holes in the walls from local uprisings against Portuguese rule. In the case of the house’s piece of incredible history emerges: it is written in the ancient Modi script.

Fading blueprints

This was, of course, once the heart of a global trading empire, so there is plenty of opulence too.

Chauhan was proudly shown Ming dynasty washbasins, boxes made of the rare Siberian amber, ivory from Mozambique, chandeliers of Belgian glass, and an exquisite purple and yellow bedspread bought and regennamed in Mumbai in 1800.

In the 300-year-old D’Sa Condiilac House in Aldona, she met a structure adapting gently to its owner. Vicente Antonio Clarence Condiilac, 73, was once a seafarer and now lives here with his wife Maria Mercedes Lucia de Santana Godinho e Condiilac, 73, and their five dogs.

Every morning, he descends the steep steps with help from a knotted rope he affixed to the ceiling.

“It’s another reminder,” says Chauhan, “that heritage endures by slowly changing with the people who inhabit them.”

It is a bit of a guess how long they will continue to endure.

These spaces bear witness to a way of life that is fast fading, says architect Gerard Da Cunha, who founded the Houses of Goa Museum in 1997. “As the world becomes a place of sameness, these homes offer character, distinctness,” he adds.

These are things Goa is losing, as change continues to race through it.

Tellingly, Chauhan’s next photobook will focus on who now lives in Goa, telling stories, among other things, of migration.

{ DOWNLOAD CENTRAL } FOREIGN TONGUES BY THE ROLLING STONES

Let the record show...

Sanjoy Narayan

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I have become a born-again fan of Mick Jagger, 83, and The Rolling Stones.

Last month, they released their 25th studio album, Foreign Tongues and, during a promotional interview on Conan O’Brien’s podcast, I heard Jagger talk about David Hockney, the great painter who died in London in June, aged 88. He spoke with an almost boyish admiration about a man who had kept reinventing himself right up to his final iPad drawing.

The irony, though Jagger didn’t seem to notice it, is that he and his bandmates — Keith Richards, 82, and Ronnie Wood, 79 — are doing precisely this. Since Hackney Diamonds arrived in 2023, ending an 18-year drought of new Stones material, the band has been rocking — and rocking forward.

Foreign Tongues, 14 tracks and just over an hour long, was assembled from sessions stretching from 2019 through last year. But this isn’t a scraps record. Only four of the tracks date to the Hackney Diamonds sessions. The rest were written and cut fresh. Jagger has described the method as deliberately unfussy: get the song down fast, before anyone in the room has the chance to pick it apart. Which shows.

Where the Stones of the 1960s and 2000s often sounded like a band assembling a Stones album by algorithm — riff here, harmonica there, Start Me Up DNA smeared over everything — this one sounds like the work of men who still enjoy being surprised by what emerges from the amp.

The guest list says a lot about where the band stands. Steve Winwood’s organ riffs

through nine of the 14 tracks, less a cameo than a genuine second voice. McCartney plays bass on one track, for the second time (the first was on Hackney Diamonds).

Robert Smith of The Cure and Chad Smith of Red Hot Chili Peppers drop in. And then there’s the quietly devastating one, *It’s a Sin*. Head incorporates a drum take from the late Chas & Dave’s final session in 2021, so that the Stones’ original rhythm section is still, somehow, here.

The first two tracks, *Rough and Twisted* and *It’s a Sin*, are the most punchy, crunchy, with a contemporary punch rather than a vintage one. Mr. Chas in vintage sleaze, with Richards’s riff at its most disreputable and Jagger doing his familiar wry-observer-of-soundtracks routine, though “sounded” recurs more pointedly later on.

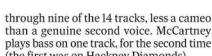
Jealous Lover drifts into the soul register of Beast of Burden (1978) and Emotional Rescue (1980). Jagger’s falsetto still, remarkably, intact. There is a cover of Amy Winehouse’s *You Know I’m No Good* on the album, handled with touching tenderness.

The record’s emotional core is Ringing Hazy, a countrified, slow-burn track. Reviewers call a love letter to America written by men watching it change into something less familiar. Jagger sings of a scoundrel whipping up the crowd, of clocks that never turn back — there is a cover of Amy Winehouse’s *You Know I’m No Good* on the album, handled with touching tenderness.

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Some critics call it the stronger record, uncluttered by comeback pressure. Others think that the back slash both. Both are true.

What struck me most was the refusal to lean on nostalgia as a crutch. Jagger has said, more than once on the promo, that he makes records for today’s listener, not yesterday’s fan. That’s the kind of thing an 83-year-old rockstar is expected to say, except here, unusually, it’s true.



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H-1B workers may lose job loss grace period of 60 days

Press Trust of India
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WASHINGTON: The US is reviewing a proposal to eliminate the 60-day window for foreign workers holding non-immigrant visas to find employment after a job loss, a move that may force them to leave the country immediately.

A proposal from the Department of Homeland Security is currently under review at the Federal Office of Management and Budget (OMB), according to its website.

If finalised, the proposed regulation would eliminate the 60-day grace period accorded to certain principal non-immigrants and their dependents if the principal's employment ceases before their period of

stay expires.

Further details of the proposal are not immediately known.

The 60-day grace period was introduced in 2017 to allow foreign workers and their dependents to stay in the US while searching for new employment after a job loss.

Immigration consultants said the Department of Homeland Security has the discretion to shorten or refuse the grace period, but has rarely done so.

The rule applies to E-1, E-2, E-3, H-1B, H-1B-1, L-1, O-1 and TN categories of non-immigrant visa holders and their dependents.

The grace period also allows US employers to more easily facilitate employment changes for existing or newly recruited

non-immigrant workers.

If the 60-day grace period is eliminated, foreign nationals whose employment ceases prematurely and their dependents would generally be required to depart the US immediately.

They would be unable to change status or employers within the United States unless US Citizenship and Immigration Services exercises its discretion to forgive the lapse in status.

The Indian-American population in the US is estimated at 5.2 million. Indian nationals are among the largest beneficiaries of H-1B employment visas, comprising 71 per cent of all successful applicants in the 2024 fiscal year.

Meanwhile, a bill recently introduced in the US Senate seeks to pause issuance of new

H-1B visas for three years and codify the \$100,000 fee imposed by the Trump administration, which was struck down by a federal court.

US Senator Tim Sheehy, a Republican from Montana, said the US should not be issuing visas that make it easier to undercut the rights of American workers.

The US issues 65,000 H-1B visas annually, along with an additional 20,000 visas for foreign workers holding advanced educational qualifications.

Because demand from India vastly exceeds the 7% annual allotment, a huge queue forms. Tens of thousands of highly skilled Indian professionals working on H-1B visas, apply for permanent residency every year.

INDO-CANADIAN RIDE OPERATOR SEXUALLY ASSAULTS WOMAN: POLICE

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
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TORONTO: An Indo-Canadian teenager has been charged with sexual assault connected to an incident at an amusement park where he was employed.

The alleged assault occurred at an amusement park in Vaughan, Ontario. York Regional Police (YRP) said on Friday that 19-year-old Jagaad Dhami, resident of Brampton in the Greater Toronto Area (GTA), was on Wednesday charged with one count of sexual assault and one count of sexual interference.

YRP said that on May 25, a woman was at the amusement park with her friends and while she "was boarding a ride, she was sexually assaulted by a ride operator as he conducted safety checks." Police released Dhami's photograph saying there may be additional victims.

Russia sanctions bill in US faces 3 hurdles

Shashank Mattoo
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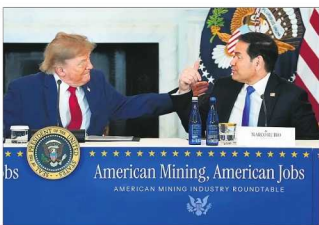
WASHINGTON: The Russia sanctions bill passed by the US Senate on Friday, which authorises tariffs of up to 100% on India, China and three other countries for buying Russian energy, faces three separate obstacles before it can reach Donald Trump for signature — the US House of Representatives is in recess until August 31, a possible September vote could collide with a Trump-Xi Jinping summit, and a coalition of House Democrats and at least one senior Republican are working to strip the tariff provisions altogether.

The House timing alone leaves a narrow window. Members return from summer recess on August 31, break again through most of October and early November as they return to their districts to fight midterm elections on November 3, and reconvene only in the weeks after. That pushes the earliest possible vote to September and the latest realistic one to late November.

September itself is complicated by China. People aware of the matter said the White House would likely prefer to keep the atmosphere around the bilateral relationship calm ahead of the anticipated Xi summit, expected on September 24.

"What we're hearing is that Washington will want to keep the general atmosphere around the US-China relationship stable and positive ahead of the anticipated Trump-Xi summit on September 24," said one of the persons cited above.

The bill has drawn sharp opposition from senior House Democrats, who argue that its structure hands the president wider tariff authority than the Ukraine question warrants. Gregory Meeks, the ranking Democrat on the House Foreign Affairs Committee, and Don Beyer, another Democratic member, said the bill in its current form is "unacceptable" and



Donald Trump and Secretary of State Marco Rubio at a roundtable on mining on Friday when Trump announced investments in minerals and battery projects to boost defence supply chains after the Iran and Ukraine war was depleted US munitions stockpiles.

would allow Trump to "dodge holding Russia accountable and impose yet more tariffs in his destructive trade wars".

Though the Paul-Wyden amendment to strike the dangerous tariff authorities failed, the vote total demonstrates that continued refinement of the Sanctioning Russia Act is imperative before it can be sent to the president's desk," their statement said. "We will continue to seek a path forward that remedies this bill's flaws."

The Paul-Wyden amendment, brought jointly by Republican Rand Paul and Democrat Ron Wyden would have stripped the tariff provisions from the bill while retaining other sanctions. It failed. But 32 senators voted in favour, including Paul crossing from his own party — a coalition already large enough to force reconciliation if the House amends the bill along similar lines.

For India, the vote comes as it and the US work to conclude an interim trade agreement. If the House passes the bill unchanged, the administration acquires a fresh tariff lever over New Delhi, distinct from the leverage already on the table.

"It's a real threat. It might not be prudent for this trade deal to remain unsettled. The EU and a number of other countries have settled their trade deals," said another person aware of India-US trade deliberations. "But some things are still politically untenable, like India's neighbours having lower rates."

The February 7 framework between New Delhi and Washington envisaged bringing the effective tariff on Indian exports to 18% from around 50% — a total that had included a 25% penalty tied to India's purchases of Russian oil.

The Russia bill would not reintroduce that penalty. It would add a new tariff layer on the same conduct, on a different legislative basis, and one the interim agreement cannot dispose of.

The bill compels the executive to act against the five named purchasers — India, China, Slovakia, Hungary and Azerbaijan — with the actual rate to be set by the office of the US Trade Representative below the 100% ceiling. A presidential waiver on certified national interest grounds is available and would trigger 180-day reassessments before Congress.

Officials in New Delhi did not respond to requests for a comment.

Kosovo PM egged in parliament



Kosovo's parliament had to be suspended on Saturday after an opposition lawmaker pelted caretaker Prime Minister Albin Kurti with eggs, as a political crisis threatens to trigger another snap election. Europe's youngest democracy has faced three elections in less than two years.

Tibet conference in Nepal pushed online

KATHMANDU: A global conference on Tibet due to take place in Nepal this month has been pushed online, organisers said on Saturday. Nepal denied that it had ordered the change.

China has long opposed international activities it sees as challenging its sovereignty. The conference of International Association for Tibetan Studies was expected to draw scholars from around the world to Kathmandu University to discuss Tibetan history, culture, religion and society.

Nocturnal 'coffee frog' discovered

COSTA RICA: A tiny greenish, nocturnal frog that thrives in coffee plantations



has been discovered in Costa Rica's central Pacific region. It measures less than four centimeters and is known as the "spring frog". Also nicknamed the "coffee frog", the species has another distinctive trait: males have a translucent throat that inflates with their short, high-pitched call. At night, when they are most active, you can hear them singing and perched on coffee shrubs, researchers said. The frogs seek out the insects in the coffee crops, and shade and moisture there.

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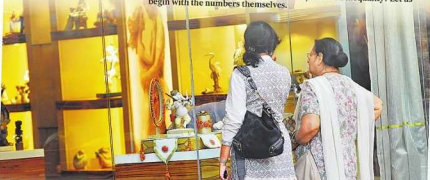
NUMBER THEORY

Everyone has an explanation for the world's biggest events. **Number Theory** tests those explanations against the evidence. Through rigorous analysis, data and fact-based reporting, it uncovers surprising insights, challenges conventional wisdom and reveals the bigger picture behind the issues shaping India and the world.

What is the actual economic inequality in India?

By Roshan Kishore and Abhishek Jha

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged Indians to cut down on gold purchases and foreign travel amid concerns over India's external balance, he was subtly hinting towards a deeper problem in the Indian economy. There is now a significant cohort of Indians whose lifestyle is at par with the rich in high-income countries and who are way ahead of how ordinary Indians earn and spend. This cohort seems to have become bigger over time, as is seen in India's rising trade deficit after economic reforms. But, statistically speaking, India's inequality data points in the opposite direction: inequality has fallen, not increased after economic reforms. How does one square this (counter-intuitive statistical) circle on inequality? Let us begin with the numbers themselves.



1

The really-rich have seen the lowest increase in spending after reforms

India's first income survey is in the process of being conducted. Existing estimates of inequality are based on consumption expenditure surveys (CES) conducted by the National Statistical Office (NSO). Comparing the monthly per capita expenditure (MPCE) of the entire CES, top 10%, top 5% and top 1% between 1993-94 and 2023-24 CES reveals – the earliest and latest after 1991 reforms – shows that top 1% have seen the lowest proportionate increase in their MPCE. The catch up of the masses vis-a-vis the classes is almost entirely a result of the former's high growth in non-food spending.

Consumption growth between 2023-24 & 1993-94

Chart shows ratio of Monthly Per Capita Expenditure between 2023-24 and 1993-94

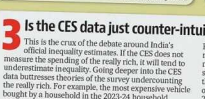
	Total
Top 1%	11.1
Top 5%	12.9
Top 10%	13.6
All classes	15.3



	Food
Top 1%	10.7
Top 5%	10.5
Top 10%	10.6
All classes	11.2



	Non-Food
Top 1%	11.3
Top 5%	14.6
Top 10%	15.9
All classes	21.6



Source: HT analysis using NSO data

2

Inequality seems to have fallen even within the really rich

Thanks to the trend described above, India's consumption inequality has fallen in the post-reform period. The Gini coefficient – the most widespread statistical measure of inequality where 0 shows perfect equality and 1 perfect inequality – has fallen from 0.32 in 1993-94 to 0.29 in 2023-24.

What about inequality within the really rich though? It makes sense to ask this question because it is eminently likely that the super-rich (those who own the rich (say, those who own a car) and only the former has seen income rise. Data seems to suggest otherwise once again. Intra-class Gini has seen the sharpest fall among the richest classes between 1993-94 and 2023-24.

Within-class Gini coefficient of MPCE

	Top 1%
1993-94	0.28
2023-24	0.15



	Top 5%
1993-94	0.24
2023-24	0.17



	Top 10%
1993-94	0.23
2023-24	0.18



	Overall
1993-94	0.33
2023-24	0.29



Gini coefficient ratio where 0 = perfect equality and 1 = perfect inequality. Source: HT analysis using NSO data

3

Is the CES data just counter-intuitive or really not representative?

This is the crux of the debate around India's official inequality estimate. If the CES does not underestimate inequality, going deeper into the data buttresses theories of the survey undercounting the really rich. For example, the most expensive vehicle bought by a household in the 2023-24 household consumption expenditure survey (HCES) cost just Rs 45 lakh. The share of such households in the HCES is eight households per million. This does not really seem to fit consumption standard of India's super rich. For example, according to the Ministry of Road Transport, Vehicle and Roadways, 4,128 Jaguar, 877 Porsche, 52 Maserati, 11 McLaren, and six Aston Martin four wheelers were registered in the country in FY 2023-24. makers that typically sell cars priced significantly above

Its 45 lakh in India. This non-enthusiastic count of 5,205 registrations amounts to a share of 16 households per million using population projections and household size from the HCES. The CES might be undercounting the rich at a wider level than just luxury cars. The share of households/population who spent on air travel in 2011-12 and 2023-24 shows a decline from 649 households/75 people per million to 471 households/609 people per million. The number of domestic air passengers in India increased from 68.6 million to 153.7 million during this period, according to the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), which translates to roughly 49,993 departures per million and 1,30,381 departures per million people in 2011-12 and 2023-24 respectively. This means that the average Indian air traveller would have to take 230 trips in 2024-25 instead of 65 in 2011-12 annually for the 16.25 data to be correct.

Domestic air passengers and estimated air travellers

	Domestic air passengers per million people: DGCA	Estimated air ticket buyers per million people: CES/HCS
2011-12	774.8	49,993.26
2023-24	469.04	110,390.58



Source: CES 2014-15, CES 2023-24, DGCA, National Commission on Population

If the CES is undercounting air travellers, can it be trusted to represent people spending on even higher value goods and services? And if the super rich are undercounted, how credible are its estimates of economic inequality? This does not, however, mean the CES is a useless statistical database. Sure, it tends to undercount the rich, but it also gives a treasure trove of information on the economic condition of a vast majority of Indians. The numbers above only tell us that one should take the inequality measures from the CES data with some amount of skepticism.

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SPORT

Padikkal passes the No.3 audition with assuring ton

His unbeaten 142 on Day 2 of the three-day warm-up tie in Colombo is timely, ahead of the first Test

Somshuvra Laha
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KOLKATA: Three deliveries into the field, unbeaten on 142 from 164 balls, Padikkal had done something more useful than make a hundred in a warm-up—he had shown how his game can evolve within an innings. This was, by all means, an audition gone well.

Padikkal's innings against Sri Lanka Cricket XI came in two phases. The first was about control. With KL Rahul alongside him, Padikkal absorbed the early movement, rotated the strike and resisted the temptation to chase the game. Rahul's 40 from 67 balls provided an experienced anchor, allowing Padikkal to gradually increase the pressure on the bowlers. He wasn't suddenly attacking everything, but he was scoring freely, and he was hitting the ball almost square when it landed on the rough. Rahul found out the hard way when he was bowled by Keshara Nuvan-tha at 92 while trying to go for a shot across the line. By then, Padikkal had moved to 52 from 61 balls, setting up the platform and giving him the chance to enter into a different mode.

Ravindra Jadeja joined him, and spin became the main challenge. Padikkal's response was particularly relevant for India, given what awaits them in Galle, venue of the first Test. His long stride allowed the left-handed batter to get close to the ball and smother turn. When the spinners were short, he swept. When they overpitched, he drove. Padikkal's reach gave him access to scoring areas without requiring extravagant movement. Jadeja proving the perfect foil at the other end and once he figured out that staying back in the crease was allowing him more time to read the turn.

The result was a second phase that was faster but did not feel riskier. Padikkal and Jadeja added 72 runs, with Jadeja's run-ning keeping the field under pressure and Padikkal increasingly finding boundaries. He reached his hundred in 121 balls, with a pull through midwicket for four, having survived a caught-and-bowled chance on 99



India's Devdutt Padikkal plays a shot on Day 2 of the warm-up match against Sri Lanka Cricket XI in Colombo on Saturday. **ACC**

off Ramesh Mendis. He retired, and pretty quickly India lost another two quick wickets. Once again Rishabh Pant was dismissed in familiar fashion, trying to hit off-spinner Ramesh Mendis over long-on but getting a leading edge to long-off. Dhruv Jurel departed soon after, but Manav Subbaraj impressed with his resilient 90-ball 41.

When he returned after the fall of the eighth wicket, Padikkal did not need time to restart. He resumed scoring almost immediately, finding boundaries off Mendis, Vishwa Fernando, Ishita Wijesundera and Lahiru Kumara. That matters because it showed his innings was not simply a long accumulation against tired bowlers. Padikkal adapted to the game state, left and then adapted again.

This was a timely hundred too

in the context of Padikkal's career. Despite a blockbuster debut against England in Dharamsala in early 2024, he has only played another Test—at Perth later that year. Sideline from the England tour because of an injury, Padikkal has been biding his time for a Test return. Bolstering his case has been Padikkal's domestic form, scoring 543 runs in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy at 60.33, including a career-best 232 against Uttarakhand.

Domestic numbers rarely guarantee a Test rebirth, though. But by staying consistent, Padikkal has priced open another opportunity, and delivered once again. With Sai Sudharsan's injury leaving India's No.3 position uncertain, Padikkal is an obvious stylistic alternative—an other left-hander, comfortable against spin and increasingly

experienced at managing different types of an innings. If India's first Test turns into a battle of patience against spin, Padikkal's method could prove useful. A tour match is not a Test, and a Sri Lanka Cricket XI is not Sri Lanka's attack.

But India are not searching for proof that Padikkal can score runs in a warm-up. They are looking for evidence that he can solve a problem at No.3. On that front, this was an unusually complete audition. He walked in at 0/1 and played like a No.3, absorbing pressure, building the innings brick by brick, slowly changing gears against spin and then resuming without fuss when asked to return. Just like how India would like it.

Brief scores: Sri Lanka Cricket XI 363/5 vs India 357/6 (D Padikkal 142*, R Jadeja 63, A Maraj 2/32).

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Sai Sudharsan out of Lanka Test series

Press Trust of India
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NEW DELHI: Talented top order batter Sai Sudharsan was on Saturday ruled out of the two-Test series against Sri Lanka after failing to recover from a big toe injury sustained during the India A tour of the island nation last month.

Sudharsan, who scored two tons in two A Test matches, was hit during the second game against Sri Lanka A and since then has been in rehabilitation at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru. "Sai Sudharsan has been ruled out of the upcoming Test series against Sri Lanka. Doctors have advised more time for biological healing. Significant improvement, but not yet sufficient for a safe return to Test cricket," according to the update from the sports science team which is monitoring the rehabilitation of the player.

The sports science team has informed the management and national selection committee. The medical-cum-fitness advice for Sudharsan reads: "Rehabilitation, strength & conditioning, and cricket-specific loads should be increased gradually and under close monitoring. The cautious approach is aimed at reducing the risk of recurrence or further complications and protecting long-term performance."

In his absence, Devdutt Padikkal, who scored a century in the practice game, will be the new No.3 batter. It will be interesting to see who replaces Sudharsan in the squad. Ravi Mumbai veteran Sarfaraz Khan seems to be a decent choice but an important member of the coaching staff as well as selection committee doesn't have a lot of faith in him.



Sai Sudharsan. **PTI**

who replaces Sudharsan in the squad. Ravi Mumbai veteran Sarfaraz Khan seems to be a decent choice but an important member of the coaching staff as well as selection committee doesn't have a lot of faith in him.

Saikia to visit COE to take stock of injury crisis
Concerned with the spate of injuries that has rocked Indian team of late, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia will be meeting Head of Cricket VVS Laxman on Sunday to take a stock of the rehabilitation management programme at the Centre of Excellence (COE).

India will be missing the services of Jasprit Bumrah (knee swelling), Sai Sudharsan (left foot big toe), Harshit Rana (hamstring), Nitish Kumar Reddy (hamstring) and Washington Sundar (quadriceps) due to various injuries. Akash Deep (lower back stress fracture) has been out for the longest time since Bengal's Ranji Trophy semi-final defeat. Adding that, white ball experts Hardik Pandya (quadriceps), Varun Chakravarthy (hamstring) and Prince Yadav (hamstring) are also COE.

Davis Cup: Korea to host India

NEW DELHI: South Korea have opted to host India on hard courts at the Olympic Tennis Centre in Seoul on September 19-19 in Davis Cup Qualifiers Round 2, setting up a potentially intriguing tie between two closely matched teams. India are currently ranked 19th and Korea 16th while the Koreans hold a slender 6-5 advantage in their head-to-head.

Flintoff quits as Eng Lions coach

LONDON: Former all-rounder Andrew Flintoff has decided to step down as head coach of the England Lions. Flintoff, who began the role in September 2024, said he prides himself in helping develop England's best young cricketers. "Unfortunately I've made the decision to step away from my role with the Lions," the 48-year-old said in a statement.

Ex-gymnasts seek probe against GFI

NEW DELHI: Former international gymnasts, including multiple-time national champion Rakesh Patra, have urged the sports ministry to order an independent inquiry into alleged procedural irregularities in the Gymnastics Federation of India's preparation of the Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit (SOM) roster. In separate letters to sports secretary Hari Ranjan Rao on July 30, Patra and another former international gymnast made similar allegations that the federation's actions violated provisions of the National Sports Governance Act, 2025 and the rules framed under it.

Guimaraes signs up with Arsenal

LONDON: Premier League champions Arsenal have completed the signing of Newcastle captain Bruno Guimaraes for a reported fee of £75 million, the two clubs announced on Saturday. The Brazilian international, who spent four-and-a-half seasons with Newcastle, has signed a "long-term contract".



Ashmita Chalhia has reached the Korea Masters final. **GETTY IMAGES**

Ashmita in first World Tour final

Press Trust of India
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ASAN: Ashmita Chalhia continued her impressive run at the Korea Masters, overcoming teenage compatriot Rakshit Rana 2-1 (13, 16-21, 13-21) to reach her maiden BWF World Tour final here on Saturday.

The 26-year-old Indian, who returned to competition in May after a month-long layoff due to a medial meniscus tear in her right knee, has enjoyed a strong comeback on the BWF World Tour, including a semi-final appearance at the Masters.

World No.35 Ashmita, who trains under Park Te-sang at the National Centre of Excellence in Gwahang, will now battle her maiden Han Qian XI for the Super 300 title.

The world No.35 Qian Xi, seeded fourth, battled past South Korea's Kim So Ram 2-0 (18-21, 21-14) in a one-hour five-minute battle in the other semi-final.

Ashmita's run also marks back-to-back BWF World Tour final appearances for Indians with Tanvi Sharda having won the Taipei Open last Sunday.

Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty at the Singapore Open, and now Ashmita at the Korea Masters.

Ashmita, who had stunned top seed and world No.22 Hina Akechi of Japan in the quarterfinals, came out aggressively and quickly moved from 2-2 to 6-2 in the opening game.

She then reeled off five straight points to establish a 13-6 lead before closing the game.

Rakshit, who was upset third seed and compatriot Tanvi in the quarters after coming from a game down, responded strongly.

The 19-year-old Pallela Gopichand Badminton Academy trainee raced to a 4-1 lead. Ashmita struggled to control the lifts and went long twice, besides finding the net, to fall 3-8 behind.

Ashish wins World U20 javelin silver

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MUMBAI: There was an unmistakable swagger as Ashish Yadav, shoulders loose, walked back to the seating area next to the javelin throw runway.

It was a walk that exuded confidence, after he had flung the spear to 74.09m. And it turned out to be the attempt that earned him silver in men's javelin at the U-20 World Athletics Championships in Eugene, Oregon on Friday night. A first on two counts.

Over the past decade, the frequency of Indians making a mark at the elite youth event has increased. But Yadav broke a drought that had lasted 10 years, becoming only the second Indian to win a javelin medal in the U-20 Worlds. With his third throw of the night he joined an exclusive group that only had Neeraj Chopra. The other first was putting India in the medals table at Eugene.

A few hours later, Chopra welcomed him into the club. "Always a great feeling to see Indian athletes competing and winning at the international level, this one is little more special for me as a javelin thrower," Chopra posted on social media.

At the 2016 edition, Chopra announced himself to the athletics world by setting the junior global record with a throw of 86.48m—a mark that still



Indian javelin thrower Ashish Yadav in Eugene. **GETTY IMAGES**

letes competing and winning at the international level, this one is little more special for me as a javelin thrower," Chopra posted on social media.

stands. It set him on the path to winning every major event—he clinched gold at the 2018 Commonwealth Games and Asian Games, the 2020 Olympics and the 2023 World Championships. "Super proud of you Ashish on your silver at the U-20 Worlds, this is just the start!" Chopra added.

Outer Delhi Warriors beat Central Delhi Kings in high-scoring clash

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NEW DELHI: Outer Delhi Warriors produced an all-round show to defeat Central Delhi Kings by 25 runs in the evening match of the Delhi Premier League at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Saturday.

Chasing 217 for victory, captain Yash Dhall powered Central Delhi Kings to a good start even as they lost Siddharth Joon early in the innings. He scored 47 off 23 balls that proved to vital as they scored 67 runs in the Powerplay.

knock to remember in the back-end of the innings, lashing a 33-ball 62 (4x6, 6x4) to dominate a ninth-wicket partnership of 50. He almost threatened to take the match away before Navdeep Saini dismissed him in the 19th over, then claimed the final wicket off the next ball to seal victory. Kings were 191 all out.

Earlier, Outer Delhi Warriors produced an aggressive batting display to post a formidable 216/9. The foundation was laid by Yajnas Sharma, who top-scored with a brisk 46 off 25 balls. His innings included four fours and three sixes, providing the momentum needed during the middle overs. Akshay Saini also made an important contribution, scoring 29 off 19 balls, while Mohit Panwar added a

useful 21 off 13.

Shivam Sharma and Harsh Tyagi delivered a tactical scores of 24 off just 10 balls. Their attacking games ensured the Warriors continued to find boundaries despite losing wickets at regular intervals. The most explosive finish came from captain Siddhant Sharma, who remained unbeaten on 19 from only five deliveries.

Although wickets fell regularly, the Warriors' batting depth and powerful finish enabled them to cross the 200-run mark comfortably. Money Grewal and Jonty Sidhu picked up two wickets apiece for Central Delhi Kings. The afternoon fixture between Purni Dhill 6 and South Delhi Supertstars was abandoned due to rain.

Jemimah out of Hundred with injury, puts Asia Cup in doubt

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NEW DELHI: India batter Jemimah Rodrigues has been ruled out of the ongoing Hundred series after suffering a hamstring injury while playing for Southern Brave, putting her participation in the upcoming Women's T20 Asia Cup in doubt.

Southern Brave confirmed on Saturday that Rodrigues has been replaced by Australian all-rounder Charlie Knott for the remainder of the tournament. "We can confirm that due to an injury suffered by Jemimah Rodrigues, we've signed Charlie Knott as our injury replacement for the remainder of The Hundred. Wishing you a speedy recovery,



Jemimah Rodrigues is out with a hamstring injury. **AP**

Jemimah Rodrigues posted on X. The 25-year-old has scored 143 runs with a highest of 42 not out in six innings for the Brave at an average of 35.75 and a strike rate of 131.9.

The Women's T20 Asia Cup begins on August 28, with India starting their campaign against Thailand on August 30. Jemimah has just under three weeks to recover from the injury.

Marijne plans to use World Cup to forge Asian Games success

Indian women open against China at WC, who'll also be the side to beat at the Asian Games for 2028 LA Games qualification

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NEW DELHI: The Indian women's hockey team is heading towards a critical juncture, defined by two major tournaments positioned agonisingly close together.

For chief coach Sjoerd Marijne, the World Cup (August 15-30) and Asian Games (September 19-October 4) represent a symbolic pathway towards the ultimate target. While the World Cup offers a stage against the global elite, the Asian Games victory carries the golden ticket — direct qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

Navigating this double-header requires not just tactical precision but vision as well. Marijne is acutely aware of the balancing act his squad must perform. Asked about the priority, the Dutchman refused to diminish the prestige of either, viewing them as interconnected stepping stones.

"I rate both tournaments really high," Marijne tells HT. "But with the Asian Games, you can qualify for the Olympics and that is our big goal — being a medalist at the 2028 Olympics. That is the dream goal. Can we reach it? We don't know, but we are hunting for it. And the major step is to qualify."

The pragmatic approach does not relegate the World Cup to a preparatory exercise. Competing at the tournament demands absolute focus, and for Marijne these tough matches are what his players need to forge resilience for the Asian Games.

"It doesn't mean that the World Cup is not important for us, because those matches can help us for Asian Games. You play a World Cup once in four years. You also want to do well. So, for me both are possible because I've already experienced it in 2018. We had the same



Chief coach Sjoerd Marijne helped the Indian women's hockey team win the Nations Cup in June in Auckland.

(schedule) and we did really well at both tournaments," said the 52-year-old.

Marijne joined the setup in January following which he helped the Salima Iete-led team achieve two major targets. India won the World Cup Qualifiers in Hyderabad in March to make the cut for the showpiece event. India then won the Nations Cup in Auckland in June to earn promotion to the elite Pro League.

The chief coach maintains that there is ample time between events to recover, emphasising that "one tournament will help the other".

Before dreaming of the Asian Games podium, India must survive a difficult World Cup pool stage. India have been grouped with Paris Olympics silver medalists China, Rio Olympics champions England and world No.18 South Africa. Only two will

progress to the next round robin. Just to qualify for that will be a tough task for the world No.9 outfit.

"It's a very tough group," says Marijne. "If you only see the numbers, then against South Africa you need to win as they are lower ranked. The other two are higher ranked." Encounters against England and China will serve as the ultimate barometer of progress. India had lost to England in the World Cup Qualifier final.

Marijne said that though the team did well there, they could have extracted more out of it. The true test will be against China, the Paris Olympics silver medalists who will also pose the biggest threat at the Asian Games.

"China is, of course, a different story," says Marijne. "They have been doing really well the last

few years. That will be the biggest challenge. And we play them first (August 16). But it'll give us insight, where we are now against the No.4 of the world. Is the gap really as it was, or has it become smaller, or maybe even bigger? Now, let's not hope that, of course."

To ensure that the gap shrinks, Marijne has overseen a cultural overhaul. Before his arrival, the team was marred by turbulence and internal rifts. The transformation into a cohesive unit required stripping away egos and fostering a collective identity. "You need more unity, focus on the team goal, not your individual goal."

This unity translates into rigorous, task-driven discipline. While the team is working on structured and defensive solidity, Marijne knows the margins are razor thin.

"Defensively stay as structured as we are and be disciplined. In the end, in big tournaments, it's about converting your chances into goals. We did really well with penalty corners (PC), but we can convert more field chances," he said.

But the reality of international hockey is that opportunities are fleeting. "Against the higher ranked teams, you'll not get 10 chances, you'll get maybe three, and you have to make at least 1-2 of them (count). You'll get maybe three PCs, you have to make 1-2 of them. Then you're going to win those matches," adds Marijne, who guided the team to fourth place at the 2021 Tokyo Olympics.

The vision is set, internal friction has been replaced by collective ambition, and the World Cup awaits as the furnace where destinies are crafted.

Lionel Messi's father Jorge, 68, dies

BUENOS AIRES: Jorge Messi, the father and agent of Lionel Messi, has died aged 68, the eight-time Ballon d'Or winner's childhood club Newell's Old Boys announced on Saturday.

Argentinian media reported Jorge Messi had passed away on Friday in a hospital in Rosario.

"His constant companionship and behind-the-scenes leadership were essential in backing every step of Lionel," Newell's Old Boys said in a social media post.

Jorge Messi was his son's first coach in Argentina and his sole companion when he first moved to Barcelona as a child, before later becoming his agent.

"My father helped me enormously. He is very critical of me. That made me always want to push myself further," Lionel Messi told DirectTV Sports in 2022. Messi's family asked the media for "humanity" during the recent World Cup amid persistent rumours over Jorge's health.

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